Section A topics on *Picnic at Hanging Rock* tend to take one of three shapes. Learn to recognise them in reading time, because each asks you to do something slightly different.

| Task type | What it asks | Typical wording |
|---|---|---|
| Construction | How Weir builds an idea through the film: framing, sound, costume, setting, structure. | How does Weir explore / depict / portray / highlight / challenge...? |
| Relationship | How two ideas connect: cause and effect, contrast, comparison or connection. | ...causes, shapes, leads to, limits; more than, as much as; despite, both...and |
| Idea / message | What the film suggests, reveals or demonstrates about an idea. | The film suggests that...; There are no...; ...is rarely...; ...is not necessarily... |

The four big ideas that sit underneath almost every topic are **nature as a fundamental force**, **the human need for rationality and control**, **time**, and **class and civilisation**. Topics will not always name these ideas directly, so practise translating unexpected wording back into them.

1. How does Weir portray nature as mysterious in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

2. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, appearances are carefully maintained, but rarely reflect reality. Discuss.

3. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, answers are unattainable. Discuss.

4. How does Weir portray the Australian landscape as mysterious in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

5. How does Weir explore the tension between human civilisation and the natural world in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

6. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, the natural world is ultimately unknowable. Discuss.

7. How does Weir explore the human desire to understand the world in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

8. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, the need to explain events is driven more by a desire for control than a desire for truth. Do you agree?

9. *Picnic at Hanging Rock* suggests that reason cannot solve every problem. Discuss.

10. How does Weir portray the limitations of authority in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

11. The greatest threat to social order in *Picnic at Hanging Rock* comes not from nature but from within society itself. Discuss.

12. *Picnic at Hanging Rock* suggests that social rules exist only to create the illusion of order. Discuss.

13. How does Weir explore different perceptions of time in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

14. How does Weir contrast the timelessness of nature and the fleeting nature of human existence in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

15. *Picnic at Hanging Rock* suggests that human existence is insignificant in the vastness of time. Discuss.

16. How does Weir depict the natural world as a source of both fascination and fear?

17. *Picnic at Hanging Rock* suggests that nature reveals the limitations of human civilisation. Discuss.

18. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, social conventions restrict individual freedom. Discuss.

19. How does Weir explore the limits to human understanding in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

20. Weir suggests that civilisation is far more fragile than it appears. Discuss.

21. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, the passing of time deepens rather than resolves the mystery of the girls' disappearance. Discuss.

22. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, the desire for certainty creates more problems than it solves. Discuss.

23. How does Weir explore the relationship between freedom and vulnerability in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

24. 'The greatest threat to civilisation comes from within.' To what extent is this true in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

25. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, people are imprisoned by their need to understand the world. Discuss.

26. How does *Picnic at Hanging Rock* explore the tension between the security of the familiar and the attraction of the unknown?

27. How does *Picnic at Hanging Rock* explore the importance of social status and appearances?

28. *Picnic at Hanging Rock* suggests that society can be disrupted but nature is timeless. Do you agree?

29. How does Weir explore the relationship between knowledge and control in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

30. How do events in *Picnic at Hanging Rock* expose true natures?

31. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, crossing boundaries can be both liberating and dangerous. Discuss.

32. 'Nothing changed – ever.' *Picnic at Hanging Rock* suggests that nature is both timeless and disruptive. To what extent do you agree?

33. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, the desire for control leads to disorder. Discuss.

34. 'What we see and what we seem are but a dream.' In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, nothing is quite what it seems. Discuss.

35. 'There's some questions got answers and some haven't.' *Picnic at Hanging Rock* suggests that we must learn to live with uncertainty. Do you agree?

36. 'People just don't disappear, my dear. Not without good reason.' The search for reasons in *Picnic at Hanging Rock* reveals more about the searchers than about the lost. Discuss.

37. 'How foolish can human creatures be.' *Picnic at Hanging Rock* is a critique of human arrogance. Discuss.

38. 'We shall only be gone a little while.' The characters of *Picnic at Hanging Rock* underestimate the forces beyond their control. Do you agree?

39. How does Weir use Hanging Rock to challenge the authority of Appleyard College?

40. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, attempts to measure the natural world lead only to greater uncertainty. Discuss.

41. *Picnic at Hanging Rock* suggests that it is difficult to escape the expectations of society. Discuss.

42. How does Weir portray the restrictions placed on young women in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

43. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, social status matters more than human suffering. Do you agree?

44. *Picnic at Hanging Rock* reveals that civilisation is powerless against time. Discuss.

45. How does Weir highlight the contrast between European culture and the Australian landscape in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

46. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, those who are drawn to nature find freedom as much as danger. Discuss.

47. *Picnic at Hanging Rock* suggests that order is not necessarily the same as safety. Discuss.

48. How does Weir use sound and music to suggest forces beyond human understanding in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

49. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, the pressure to keep up appearances causes more suffering than the disappearance itself. Discuss.

50. *Picnic at Hanging Rock* celebrates the beauty of the natural world as much as it fears it. Do you agree?

51. 'Waiting a million years, just for us.' In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, nature is indifferent to human concerns. Discuss.

52. How does Weir depict Mrs Appleyard's need for control, and its consequences, in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

53. *Picnic at Hanging Rock* suggests that the past can never be fully known. Discuss.

54. 'We shall only be gone a little while.' *Picnic at Hanging Rock* shows that human plans are fragile in the face of time. Discuss.

55. How does Weir use costume to explore class and conformity in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

56. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, rationality limits people as much as it protects them. Discuss.

57. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, encounters with nature expose vulnerabilities. Discuss.

58. How does the girls' disappearance change the world of *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

59. To what extent does *Picnic at Hanging Rock* suggest that the desire to understand the world is ultimately futile?

60. How does the film challenge the belief that every mystery can be solved?

61. The film suggests that human systems of order collapse when confronted by nature. To what extent do you agree?

62. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, certainty is an illusion. Discuss.

63. How does Weir reveal the weaknesses beneath civilisation in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

64. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, the order and rules of civilisation are rendered meaningless by the natural world. Discuss.

65. Human systems of order are insignificant when confronted by the natural world. Discuss.

66. *Picnic at Hanging Rock* highlights how nature is timeless and mysterious. Discuss.

67. Weir demonstrates that attempts to preserve order are ultimately pointless. Discuss.

68. *Picnic at Hanging Rock* portrays human order as temporary rather than enduring. Discuss.

69. Peter Weir's film explores a world filled with mysteries beyond human understanding. Discuss.

## Overview

Peter Weir's *Picnic at Hanging Rock* (1975) opens with a title card dating its events to St Valentine's Day, 1900: a party of schoolgirls from Appleyard College picnics at Hanging Rock, near Mount Macedon in Victoria, and several members of the party disappear without trace. The film never explains what happened. Instead, it studies how a rigid, ordered colonial society reacts when something happens that its rules, clocks and explanations cannot contain. Knowing where the story comes from, when it is set and how it was made will help you write about Weir's choices rather than just the plot.

## Joan Lindsay's Novel

The film is adapted from Joan Lindsay's 1967 novel of the same name. Lindsay deliberately blurred fact and fiction, presenting the disappearance as if it might have happened and declining to say whether it did. That ambiguity became part of the story's legend: many readers and viewers came to believe the events were real. A final chapter that Lindsay cut from the novel, offering a strange, quasi-supernatural resolution, was published after her death; it plays no part in the film.

### Analysis

You are studying the film, not the novel. Weir keeps Lindsay's refusal to resolve the mystery and makes it the centre of the viewing experience: the audience, like the characters, is left wanting an answer that never arrives. When you write about 'unresolved mysteries', remember that this is a deliberate construction, not a gap.

## Peter Weir and the Australian New Wave

*Picnic at Hanging Rock* was one of the defining films of the Australian New Wave, a revival of local filmmaking in the 1970s supported by new government film funding. Directed by Peter Weir from a screenplay by Cliff Green, it was a major critical and commercial success and helped bring Australian cinema to international audiences. Appleyard College was filmed at

Martindale Hall in South Australia, while the picnic and search scenes were shot at Hanging Rock itself.

### Analysis

The New Wave was partly about Australians telling stories about their own landscape and history. Weir's film looks back at colonial society with a mixture of beauty and unease: the European culture of the college looks lovely but out of place against the ancient Australian bush. This tension between imported civilisation and the land is at the heart of most essay topics.

## Victoria in 1900

In 1900 Victoria was still a British colony; Federation would come on 1 January 1901. Wealthy colonial society modelled itself on Britain: its schools taught deportment, French, poetry and the accomplishments expected of young ladies, and its social life was governed by strict rules about class, dress and behaviour. Girls were laced into corsets, gloved and hatted outdoors, and expected to be decorative, obedient and chaste.

Class divisions were sharp. The Fitzhuberts are landed gentry; Albert, their groom, is a working man who grew up in an orphanage; Sara, his sister, is a ward whose fees go unpaid. Mrs Appleyard's college depends on wealthy parents' money and on its reputation for respectability.

### Analysis

The rules of this society explain much of what we see: the gloves Mrs Appleyard allows the girls to remove only 'once the drag has passed through Woodend', the horror at Miss McCraw being seen without her skirt, the police assumption that the explanation must be a man. Weir shows how fragile these conventions are once they meet something beyond them.

## Hanging Rock

Hanging Rock is a volcanic formation in the Macedon Ranges, north-west of Melbourne, and lies on the traditional lands of the Dja Dja Wurrung, Taungurung and Wurundjeri Woi-wurrung peoples. Geologically it is relatively young, a point Miss McCraw makes in the film, but in human terms it is ancient. Its jagged pinnacles, narrow passages and balanced boulders give it the maze-like quality Weir's camera exploits.

### Analysis

The colonial characters treat the Rock as a picnic spot and a curiosity to be measured. The film suggests that it existed long before them and will outlast them. The settlers' lack of any real relationship with the land, including the Indigenous history they overlook, is part of what makes it seem so alien and threatening to them.

## The Film Script

A transcript of the film's dialogue is available online: *Picnic at Hanging Rock* film transcript (script-o-rama). Use it to check the exact wording of quotes, which can differ from the published screenplay. The transcript leaves out numbers (times and dates), so check those against the film.

## The Look and Sound of the Film

Cinematographer Russell Boyd gave the film its dreamy, soft-focus look, with diffused light, slow motion and lingering shots of the landscape. The soundtrack mixes Gheorghe Zamfir's haunting pan flute, original music by Bruce Smeaton, European classical pieces such as the slow movement of Beethoven's Fifth Piano Concerto, and an unsettling low rumble associated with the Rock.

### Analysis

These choices create the film's central tension between beauty and menace. The images are lovely, almost like paintings, but the sound and pacing keep the viewer uneasy. See the Film Techniques section for how to use them in essays.

Your set text is Peter Weir's 1975 film, not Joan Lindsay's 1967 novel. The film follows the novel closely, but the novel contains events and explanations that never appear on screen. Anything that exists only in the novel cannot be used as evidence in your essay, and using it tells the assessor you are not writing about the film.

## What Happens Differently in the Novel

- **Sara's death.** In the novel, Sara is found days later beneath the school's tower, apparently a suicide. In the film, the head gardener finds her body in the greenhouse; how she died is never shown.
- **Mrs Appleyard's death.** In the novel, she jumps from a peak on the Rock. In the film, a closing voice-over reports that her body was found at the base of the Rock and that 'it is

believed she fell while attempting to climb the rock'.

- **Miss Lumley.** In the novel, she leaves with her brother Reg, and both die in a hotel fire. In the film, she simply resigns.
- **Mademoiselle.** In the novel, she announces she is getting married and leaves the college. In the film, she is still there at the end, dining with Mrs Appleyard.
- **Miss McCraw.** In the novel, a frill of calico thought to be from her dress is found in 1903. The film gives no such clue.

## The Missing Final Chapter

Lindsay cut the novel's final chapter before publication. It was published after her death, in 1987, as *The Secret of Hanging Rock*. In it, the girls and a woman who seems to be Miss McCraw throw off their corsets and pass through a 'hole in space' in the Rock, while Irma is shut out when the hanging boulder tilts. This chapter has nothing to do with the film. Weir deliberately leaves the disappearance unexplained, and that refusal to explain is one of the most important things to analyse. Never use the missing chapter as an 'answer'.

## How to Stay on the Film

- Name the director, not the author: 'Weir suggests', not 'Lindsay suggests'.
- Use film evidence: shots, framing, sound, music, costume, setting and editing, as well as dialogue.
- If you have read the novel, check every detail you plan to use against the film. If you cannot point to the moment on screen, leave it out.
- Use the novel only as context, and only in passing: for example, that Lindsay blurred fact and fiction, and that Weir keeps the mystery unresolved.

## Social Values

### Order, Rules and Respectability

Appleyard College values discipline, punctuality and propriety above all. Mrs Appleyard's instructions before the picnic about gloves, 'tomboy foolishness', snakes and returning 'at about 8' show a world that tries to anticipate and control every risk. The film questions whether these rules create real order or only the appearance of it: when the girls vanish, the rules offer no answer, and the institution begins to collapse.

### Class and Social Hierarchy

Wealth and status decide who belongs. Sara, an orphan whose fees are ‘impossibly overdue’, is excluded from the picnic and treated harshly; Mrs Appleyard insists the college is not a ‘charitable institution’. Michael and Albert’s friendship across the class divide stands out as a rare challenge to these values.

### Femininity and Restraint

The girls are dressed in white, corseted and gloved, praised for beauty and refinement. The film links this ideal of femininity to repression: the girls who climb the Rock shed their shoes, stockings and gloves, and the community’s reaction to the disappearance focuses obsessively on bodies and sexual danger.

## Cultural Values

### Rationality and Science

The characters trust measurement, investigation and explanation. Miss McCraw studies geometry and geology; Sergeant Bumpher interviews witnesses and organises searches; the doctor examines Irma. The film presents a world that does not yield to these methods, suggesting the limits of a purely rational worldview.

### European Culture in the Australian Landscape

The college is a piece of England transplanted to the bush: Botticelli prints, Valentine’s poetry, cultivated flowers, high tea and classical music. Weir sets this imported culture against an ancient landscape it does not understand, revealing the colonists’ sense of being outsiders in the land they occupy.

### Romanticism and the Sublime

Some characters, especially Miranda and Michael, are drawn to nature as something beautiful, spiritual and liberating. This Romantic longing for connection with nature coexists with fear: the Rock is both enchanting and terrifying.

## Key Ideas and Vocabulary

The film can be strange and confusing, so it helps to know the main ideas before you watch. The most fundamental idea is that the natural world is powerful, overwhelming and

mysterious, while the human world tries to measure, quantify and make rules to create a sense of control. Weir's film explores an event that challenges every illusion of control his characters have. The vocabulary below will help you write about each key idea with precision.

### Nature as a Fundamental Force

From the opening image of the Rock, the audience sees nature as monumental and powerful. But it is not only the Rock: Weir provides many vignettes of trees, birds, lizards and insects that present the varied, multifaceted natural world beyond human control. Some characters, like Edith, are afraid of and repelled by the untamed bush; others, like Miranda, are drawn to it, literally walking away from the constraints of the human world. Every other idea in the film relates to nature, so any essay on *Picnic at Hanging Rock* needs to analyse nature in some way.

- **Nature:** natural environment, landscape, wilderness, Australian bush, surrounding landscape, untamed world, world of nature, natural realm, surrounding wilderness.
- **Nature as a mysterious force:** elemental forces of nature, impenetrability of the wilderness, untameable power of nature, overwhelming nature of the wilderness, primordial landscape, inscrutable forces of nature, unknowable dimensions of the wilderness, enigmatic world of the Australian landscape, ancient and indifferent landscape.

### The Human Need for Rationality and Control

Because life and nature are so overwhelming, people quantify, measure and control the world around them so that they feel powerful and clever. Throughout the film, characters try to explain the mystery of the disappearance, while others recognise the limits of human knowledge. Marion and Miss McCraw measure, calculate and put numbers on the world. As the party approaches the Rock, there is a short discussion about how old it is, as though knowing its age will help them understand it.

- **Order:** structure, stability, certainty, predictability, clarity, understanding, balance, control, rationality, coherence.
- **Chaos:** disorder, uncertainty, unpredictability, confusion, mystery, wilderness, irrationality.
- **Desire for knowledge:** need to understand, the importance of learning, feeling of expertise, prioritisation of education, promotion of intellect, the search for reason, accumulation of information, desire to comprehend, need to make sense.

- **Measurement:** quantification, imposition of order, reduction of data, transforming the unknowable, a means of establishing order, faith in mathematical understanding.

### Class and Civilisation

As part of the effort to measure and control the world, humans have created 'civilisation', the opposite of the natural world. Appleyard College is its obvious symbol: a monumental colonial building surrounded by a manicured lawn in the middle of the Australian bush. Even nature is controlled there: plants grow in a greenhouse and exotic flowers are arranged in vases. Costume carries the same idea: girls are strapped into corsets every morning, policemen wear brightly polished buttons, Mrs Appleyard's hair is a carefully coiffed beehive. The characters are arranged into serving classes and ruling classes. Everyone has rules to follow, and the rules make them feel they have tamed the world. As Weir reveals, they have not.

- **The ordered world of Appleyard College:** carefully regulated environment, controlled world of the school, a world governed by rules and expectations, institutional world of Appleyard College, the structured life of the schoolgirls, artificial order of the school environment, the confined world of Appleyard College, the institutional structures that govern the girls, the school as a symbol of civilisation.
- **The social structure of Edwardian society:** the rigid social structures of the time, conventions of polite society, social codes of the 1900s, the social mores of the time, constraints of the civilised world, accepted behaviours and conventions, the hierarchical nature of Edwardian society, the conventions of British colonial culture, the values of colonial society.

### Time

Time is a tool of measurement, so it belongs with rationality and control, but it is important enough to deserve its own place. The characters are obsessed with time: the girls disappear on a specified date, there are clocks and watches everywhere, and the characters are disturbed when they stop. In contrast stands the natural world, which operates on a scale that is almost incomprehensible: the Rock is millions of years old. Weir also plays with the audience's sense of time by slowing some of the action down and presenting it in a dreamlike, timeless way.

- **Human-scale time:** temporal order on the world, systems of clocks, schedules and routines, linear notions of time, time as quantifiable, time as a boundary that separates and defines, linear progression of human life, human attempts to organise the passage of time, the measured rhythm of civilisation.

- **Time in the natural world:** collapse of established routines, cyclical and fluid nature of time, a timescale that transcends human experience, transcending human life, shifting and deceptive in the natural world, geological time, the eternal cycles of nature, the ageless landscape.

## Nature as a Fundamental Force

> *Miranda* (voice-over): 'What we see and what we seem are but a dream, a dream within a dream.'

> *Mrs Appleyard*: 'The vicinity is renowned for its venomous snakes and poisonous ants of various species.'

> *Mrs Appleyard*: 'The Rock is extremely dangerous, and you are therefore forbidden any tomboy foolishness in the matter of exploration.'

> *Irma*, as the Rock comes into view: 'Waiting a million years, just for us.'

> *Edith*: 'Why can't we just sit on this log and look at the ugly old rock from here?'

> *Edith*: 'It's nasty here.'

> *Edith* (remembering the Rock): 'It was a cloud… it was red.'

> *Michael*, of the Rock: 'It comes back at night in dreams.'

> *Sara*, in Albert's dream: 'I've come a long way to see ya, and now I must go.'

> *Sara*, after the disappearance: Miranda had many 'secrets'; 'she knew she wouldn't come back.'

## The Human Need for Rationality and Control

*Mr Hussey*: ‘No one knows. No one saw her leave. We were asleep.’

*Sergeant Bumpher* (to Edith): ‘Was there a man?’

*Mrs Bumpher*, reporting local gossip: ‘It couldn’t be local… No one around here would do a thing like that.’

*Mrs Bumpher*, to her husband: ‘People just don’t disappear, my dear. Not without good reason.’

*A townsman* outside the police station: ‘We’ve got a bloody right to know.’

*The doctor*, examining Irma: her unmarked feet are ‘very strange’.

*The doctor*, on Irma’s survival: ‘Remarkable.’

*Mrs Appleyard*, of Miss McCraw: how could her ‘masculine intellect’ be ‘spirited away… like a silly schoolgirl’?

*The head gardener*: ‘There’s some questions got answers and some haven’t.’

*Mrs Appleyard*, on Irma being the only girl found: ‘This makes it worse.’

*Michael*, to Albert: ‘I wake up every night in a cold sweat. Just wondering if they’re still alive.’

*Michael*, insisting on searching the Rock himself: the girls ‘may be out there dying of thirst.’

*Miss Lumley*, rebuked by Mrs Appleyard: Irma’s discovery is ‘wonderful news.’

## Time

> *Miranda*, of her watch: ‘Don’t wear it anymore. Can’t stand the ticking above my heart.’

> *Irma*, of Miranda’s watch: she would wear it ‘always… even in the bath.’

> *Mr Hussey*: ‘Blowed if me watch hasn’t stopped. Dead on twelve.’

> *Miss McCraw*: ‘Stopped at twelve. Never stopped before. Must be something magnetic.’

> *Mr Hussey*: ‘Well after two, I’d say. We’d better be careful. I promised Mrs Appleyard I’d have you lot back at the college by eight.’

> *Marion*: ‘I should like to make a few measurements of the rock if we have time.’

> *Irma*: ‘We’ll be back long before tea.’

> *Miranda*: ‘Everything begins and ends at exactly the right time and place.’

> *Edith*: ‘When are we going home?’

> *Miranda*, to Mademoiselle: ‘We shall only be gone a little while.’

> *Mrs Appleyard*, remembering Bournemouth: ‘Nothing changed – ever.’

## Class and Civilisation

> *Mrs Appleyard*: ‘You may remove your gloves once the drag has passed through Woodend.’

> *Mrs Appleyard*: 'Mr Hussey! I shall expect you back, Miss McCraw and Mademoiselle, at about 8.'

> *Mrs Appleyard*: 'There are several sets of tuition fees impossibly overdue… Sara Waybourne, for instance.'

> *Mrs Appleyard*: Appleyard College is not a 'charitable institution'.

> *Marion*, looking down from the Rock: 'Whatever can those people be doing down there? Like a lot of ants. Surprising the number of human beings are without purpose. Although it is probable they're performing some function unknown to themselves.'

> *Miss McCraw*, as the party settles beneath the Rock: 'How foolish can human creatures be.'

> *Albert*: if 'the bloody cop and the bloody… tracker and the bloody dog can't find 'em, well, no one bloody can.'

> *Albert*, to Michael: 'I say the crude things. You just think 'em.'

> *Edith*, of the Fitzhuberts: they 'might be the only living creatures in the whole world.'

> *Mrs Appleyard*, to Sara: 'You will be returned to the orphanage.'

> *Sara*, repeating Mrs Appleyard's words to herself: 'This is not a charitable institution.'

> *Miss Lumley*, to Sara: Sara is 'not to go on the picnic.'

## Beauty, Innocence and Appearance

> *Mademoiselle de Poitiers*: 'Now I know… Miranda is a Botticelli angel.'

> *Mademoiselle*, embracing Irma on her return: she is ‘prettier than ever’.

> *Mrs Appleyard*, to the students: they can ‘thank the Lord for this merciful deliverance of our dear classmate Irma’.

> *Miss Lumley*, of strapping Sara to the gymnasium wall: it is ‘for her own good’, to cure her ‘terrible stooping’.

## Miranda



Miranda leads the girls up the Rock and does not return. Beautiful, serene and drawn to the natural world, she is idealised by almost everyone around her.

> ‘What we see and what we seem are but a dream, a dream within a dream.’ – *the film’s opening voice-over*.

> ‘Don’t wear it anymore. Can’t stand the ticking above my heart.’ – *rejecting her jewelled*

> *watch at the picnic.*

> ‘Everything begins and ends at exactly the right time and place.’ – *on top of the Rock, just before she disappears.*

> ‘Someday, Sara, you shall have to come home with me to the station… meet my sweet, funny family for yourself.’ – *to Sara on the morning of the picnic.*

> ‘You must learn to love someone else, apart from me.’ – *to Sara, as if anticipating her own absence.*

> ‘We shall only be gone a little while.’ – *reassuring Mademoiselle as the girls set off to explore.*

## Marion



Marion is intellectual and detached, taking measurements on the Rock with a protractor. She does not return.

> ‘I should like to make a few measurements of the rock if we have time.’ – *asking permission to explore.*

> ‘I do wish you’d stop talking for once.’ – *to Edith during the climb.*

> ‘Whatever can those people be doing down there? Like a lot of ants. Surprising the number of human beings are without purpose.’ – *looking down on the picnickers from the Rock*.

## Irma



Irma is the heiress of the group and the only climbing girl who comes back, with no memory of what happened.

> She would wear Miranda’s watch ‘always… even in the bath.’ – *at the picnic*.

> ‘Waiting a million years, just for us.’ – *awed by the Rock on the journey*.

> ‘We’ll be back long before tea.’ – *before the climb*.

> ‘If only we could stay out all night and watch the moon rise.’ – *on the Rock*.

> ‘Poor Edith. We’ll go back soon.’ – *to Edith before the girls disappear*.

## Edith



Edith is plump, complaining and frightened. She keeps her hat, gloves, shoes and stockings on, and runs screaming from the Rock.

> ‘Why can’t we just sit on this log and look at the ugly old rock from here?’ – *during the climb.*

> ‘It’s nasty here.’ – *as the others are drawn further in.*

> ‘When are we going home?’ – *repeatedly, during the climb.*

> ‘It was a cloud… it was red.’ – *remembering, when she returns to the Rock with Sergeant Bumpher.*

> Miss McCraw ‘was funny’ – *explaining that she was climbing without her skirt.*

> The Fitzhuberts ‘might be the only living creatures in the whole world.’ – *after the picnic meal.*

## Mrs Appleyard



The headmistress embodies authority, convention and institutional control. As events slip beyond her control, she unravels.

> ‘You may remove your gloves once the drag has passed through Woodend.’ – *instructions before the picnic.*

> ‘The Rock is extremely dangerous, and you are therefore forbidden any tomboy foolishness in the matter of exploration.’ – *warning the girls.*

> ‘Mr Hussey! I shall expect you back, Miss McCraw and Mademoiselle, at about 8.’ – *as the drag departs.*

> ‘This makes it worse.’ – *chiding Miss Lumley for calling Irma’s discovery ‘wonderful news’.*

> ‘There are several sets of tuition fees impossibly overdue… Sara Waybourne, for instance.’ – *as the college faces financial pressure.*

> ‘We shall have to make other arrangements.’ – *to Sara, about her unpaid fees.*

> ‘You will be returned to the orphanage.’ – *in her final meeting with Sara.*

> Bournemouth was ‘a delightful place’ where ‘nothing changed – ever.’ – *reminiscing with*

> *Mademoiselle at dinner.*

> She had come to ‘depend so much on Greta McCraw’ and her ‘masculine intellect’: ‘How could she allow herself to be spirited away?’ – *at the same dinner.*

## Sara Waybourne



An orphan and ward of the college, Sara is forbidden from the picnic and devoted to Miranda. She is later found dead.

> Miranda had many ‘secrets’: ‘she knew she wouldn’t come back.’ – *after the disappearance.*

> At the orphanage she had her head shaved for telling the matron she wanted to be a ‘circus rider’. – *confiding in Minnie.*

> ‘This is not a charitable institution.’ – *repeating Mrs Appleyard’s words to herself, beneath a painting of a woman holding two babies.*

> ‘I’ve come a long way to see ya, and now I must go.’ – *to Albert, in his dream on the night of her death.*

## Miss McCraw



The mathematics mistress, admired by Mrs Appleyard for her ‘masculine intellect’. She climbs the Rock alone and does not return.

> ‘Stopped at twelve. Never stopped before. Must be something magnetic.’ – *when the watches are found stopped.*

> The Rock is ‘quite young, geologically speaking.’ – *explaining its volcanic origin at the picnic.*

> ‘How foolish can human creatures be.’ – *reflecting that the picnickers have come for pleasure to a place of ‘venomous snakes and poisonous ants’.*

## Mademoiselle de Poitiers



The French mistress is warm, romantic and admired by the students, but increasingly anxious for answers.

> ‘Now I know… Miranda is a Botticelli angel.’ – *watching Miranda.*

> Irma is ‘prettier than ever.’ – *embracing Irma, before questioning her about what she told the police.*

## Miss Lumley



The junior mistress is timid and fearful of Mrs Appleyard. She eventually resigns.

> Irma’s discovery is ‘wonderful news.’ – *rebuked by Mrs Appleyard.*

> Sara is ‘not to go on the picnic.’ – *reminding Sara, though she is not going either.*

> Strapping Sara to the wall is ‘for her own good’, to cure her ‘terrible stooping’. – *in the gymnasium.*

## Michael Fitzhubert



A young English aristocrat visiting his uncle and aunt. He watches the girls cross the stream and becomes obsessed with finding them.

> ‘I wake up every night in a cold sweat. Just wondering if they’re still alive.’ – *to Albert*.

> The girls ‘may be out there dying of thirst.’ – *insisting on searching the Rock himself*.

> ‘It comes back at night in dreams.’ – *telling Albert he can’t stop thinking about the Rock*.

## Albert Crundall



The Fitzhuberts’ groom: earthy, practical and loyal. He finds Irma and, without knowing it, is Sara’s brother.

> If ‘the bloody cop and the bloody… tracker and the bloody dog can’t find ‘em, well, no one

> bloody can.' – *trying to talk Michael out of searching*.

> He dreams of his 'kid sister' on the night of Sara's death. – *telling Michael about the dream*.

> 'I say the crude things. You just think 'em.' – *to Michael, at the stream*.

## The Investigators and the Town

> Mr Hussey: 'No one knows. No one saw her leave. We were asleep.' – *reporting to Mrs Appleyard and Sergeant Bumpher*.

> Sergeant Bumpher: 'Was there a man?' – *questioning Edith*.

> Sergeant Bumpher: 'As the girls were jumping the creek, what were you thinking of?' – *interviewing Michael, who answers by pointing to a swan vase*.

> Mrs Bumpher: 'It couldn't be local… No one around here would do a thing like that.' – *repeating the town's gossip*.

> Mrs Bumpher: 'People just don't disappear, my dear. Not without good reason.' – *to her husband, who has no answers*.

> A townsman: 'We've got a bloody right to know.' – *outside Bumpher's house after Irma is found*.

> The doctor: Irma's unmarked feet are 'very strange'. – *listing her injuries*.

> The doctor: 'Remarkable.' – *on Irma surviving a week on the Rock*.

> Mr Hussey: 'Well after two, I'd say. We'd better be careful.' – *after his watch stops at the*

> *picnic.*

> The head gardener: 'There's some questions got answers and some haven't.' – *one of the film's few direct statements of its idea.*

## Mrs Appleyard and Sara Waybourne

The film's most painful relationship is one of power. Mrs Appleyard is upright, ornately dressed and usually framed above other characters or behind her desk; Sara is small, plain, stooped and often seated or diminished in the frame. Sara loves poetry and feeling; Mrs Appleyard values rules and fees. As the college comes under pressure, Mrs Appleyard turns her frustration on Sara, the one person with no family or money to protect her.

### Key Quotes

- *Mrs Appleyard:* 'There are several sets of tuition fees impossibly overdue… Sara Waybourne, for instance.'
- *Mrs Appleyard:* 'We shall have to make other arrangements.'
- *Mrs Appleyard:* Appleyard College is not a 'charitable institution'.

### Key Ideas

- Class and social hierarchy
- Authority and cruelty
- Reason versus emotion
- Victim or agent of her own fate?

### Sara Waybourne: Victim of Fate or Author of Her Own Demise?

One of the most significant minor characters, Sara is Miranda's devoted admirer. We first see her watching Miranda wash her face and presenting her with a Valentine's card. Her outsider status is established early: she is prevented from going to the picnic and must stay behind to learn poetry, but she thinks her own poetry is better than the classic and refuses to learn it. Mrs Appleyard nags her about her posture throughout, a good symbol of how Sara doesn't, or won't, fit in. Late in the film we learn that her guardian has not been paying her fees. Her story is 'doomed', as Irma predicts.

Sara is contradictory. She stands up to Mrs Appleyard, and it is easy to cheer for her. But in Edwardian times orphans were near the bottom of the class ladder, and a girl like Sara could easily have ended up closer to Minnie the maid's position, like her brother Albert. She also has a comfortable life for an orphan, lounging about a privileged boarding school writing poetry. Yet she is bullied by Mrs Appleyard, and Miss Lumley ties her to a wall to 'improve' her posture.

| One side of Sara's story | On the other hand |
|---|---|
| Miranda: 'Someday, Sara, you shall have to come home with me to the station... meet my sweet, funny family for yourself.' | Sara says Miranda had many 'secrets... she knew she wouldn't come back'. |
| Miranda: 'You must learn to love someone else, apart from me.' | Sara shakes her head at this advice, but she has a brother she apparently doesn't keep in touch with. |
| Miss Lumley reminds Sara that she is 'not to go on the picnic'. | But Miss Lumley is sympathetic, because she is not allowed to go on the picnic either. |
| Mrs Appleyard: 'There are several sets of tuition fees impossibly overdue... Sara Waybourne, for instance.' | Mrs Appleyard: 'This is not a charitable institution.' |
| Sara shakes her head when Mrs Appleyard says, 'We shall have to make other arrangements.' | Sara grew up in an orphanage with her brother Albert, so she must have some understanding of her position in society. |
| Sara tells Minnie that she had her head shaved in the orphanage for telling the matron she wanted to be a 'circus rider'. | Sara bit the matron's arm until it bled. |
| Miss Lumley ties Sara to the gymnasium wall to 'cure her terrible stooping'. | Mademoiselle has the courage to stand up to Mrs Appleyard, but Miss Lumley is too afraid (until she finally resigns). |
| Just before Sara dies, Weir focuses on her photograph of Miranda, suggesting that Sara is all alone. | Albert dreams of his 'kid sister' on the night of her death. |
| The head gardener finds Sara's body in the greenhouse. | Mrs Appleyard claims that Sara's guardian took her away. |

**Question to answer:** Is Sara a victim of fate, or does she bring about her own demise?

### Control and the Natural World: a Spectrum

Sara's surname is symbolic: 'Waybourne' sounds like 'wayward', or contrary. Sara does not fit the rigid hierarchy of Appleyard College and is the complete antithesis of Mrs Appleyard. Try placing the characters (Sara, Mrs Appleyard, Miranda, Miss McCraw, Michael, Albert, Mademoiselle, Miss Lumley, Irma) on a spectrum from **control** (logic and hierarchy) to **untamed forces** (nature and mystery), and label each with a phrase:

- **Towards control:** systematic regulation, a desire for logic and reason, the established conventions of social order, the pursuit of understanding and certainty, the acceptance of social conventions, submission to established systems, the security of rationality and an ordered world, a belief in the authority of social institutions, an attempt to create meaning through systems, the triumph of structure over the natural world, a fear of the unknown.
- **Towards untamed forces:** the wildness of nature, untamed forces, elemental forces, the enigma of life, challenges to established order, the unpredictability of the natural world, primal forces, the fragility of human attempts to impose order, the uncertainty of nature, the raw energy of the natural world, the mystery of nature.

## Miranda and Sara

Sara adores Miranda, who is kind to her and seems to offer belonging. Miranda's gentle advice that Sara 'must learn to love someone else' reads, in hindsight, like a farewell. With Miranda gone, Sara is completely alone; just before Sara's death, Weir focuses on her photograph of Miranda.

### Key Quotes

- *Miranda:* 'Someday, Sara, you shall have to come home with me to the station… meet my sweet, funny family for yourself.'
- *Miranda:* 'You must learn to love someone else, apart from me.'
- *Sara:* Miranda had many 'secrets… she knew she wouldn't come back.'

### Key Ideas

- Love and isolation
- Foreshadowing
- The cost of the disappearance for those left behind

## Michael and Albert

Michael is a privileged young Englishman; Albert is the Fitzhuberts' groom, raised in an orphanage. At the picnic Albert makes crude remarks about the girls while Michael watches them in silence. The search draws them together: Albert rescues Michael from the Rock, and their conversations grow into a genuine friendship that ignores the social hierarchy around them. In their final scene Albert tells Michael about his dream of his 'kid sister', a connection to Sara that neither fully understands.

### Key Quotes

- *Albert:* If 'the bloody cop and the bloody… tracker and the bloody dog can't find 'em, well, no one bloody can.'
- *Michael:* The girls 'may be out there dying of thirst.'
- *Michael:* 'I wake up every night in a cold sweat. Just wondering if they're still alive.'

### Key Ideas

- Friendship across class
- Acceptance (Albert) versus the search for understanding (Michael)
- Instinct and intuition

### An Evolving Relationship

Through Michael and Albert's friendship, Weir suggests that the natural world transcends the rigid class divisions of society. Their shared experiences in nature transform both men, while also leaving them disoriented and stripped of certainty. Theirs is the only relationship that genuinely evolves through the film: as they become immersed in the mystery, their friendship mirrors nature's ability to transcend the social divisions that once separated them.

| Beginning | Middle | End |
| --- | --- | --- |
| Although Albert belongs to a different class, he is friendly and open towards Michael at the picnic, offering to share a drink. Michael returns the friendliness. Albert comments candidly on the girls' appearance as they cross the stream. When Michael calls him 'crude', Albert replies, 'I say the crude things. You just think 'em.' | Albert believes the girls must be dead, but agrees to help Michael search. He accepts that Michael wants to stay on the Rock overnight and lies to Michael's uncle for him. Albert finds Michael the next day, recognises the importance of the torn fabric in his hand, then searches the Rock and finds Irma. | In Michael's final scene he shares his dreams with Albert: he can't help thinking about the Rock; 'It comes back at night in dreams.' Albert responds with his own 'funny dream', in which he sees his sister Sara, accompanied by the powerful smell of pansies. |

**Sentence starters:** *Rather than reinforcing social hierarchy, Michael and Albert's relationship...; Unlike the rigid social world they inhabit...; Against the backdrop of a transcendent natural world...; In contrast to the strict social hierarchies of Edwardian society...; Eschewing the social mores of the time... + becomes more..., resists..., goes beyond..., evolves from... to..., surpasses..., overcomes..., redefines...*

**Comparative statements to agree, disagree or partly agree with:**

- Throughout the film, Albert is more open to new experiences than Michael.
- Albert's connection to nature is instinctive, whereas Michael's must be learned.
- Michael learns more from Albert than Albert learns from Michael.
- Michael's search for the girls is ultimately a search for himself, while Albert remains secure in his identity.
- Albert embodies acceptance, while Michael embodies the search for understanding.

### Dreams

At the end of the film both men have dreams. Michael's is about the Rock; Albert's is about his sister Sara, which seems random, because for most of the film we did not know they were related. Now, just after Sara has died, Albert dreams about her. Possible readings: for Weir, dreams are symbolic of the mysterious powers of nature; because dreams are disconnected from the rational mind, they symbolise a natural world beyond our control; people and nature are connected in ways that transcend logical thought, and dreams symbolise these connections.

## Albert and Sara

Albert and Sara are brother and sister, separated in the orphanage. The film never brings them together: Albert does not know his sister is at the college a few miles away, and Sara does not keep in touch with him. On the night of Sara's death, Albert dreams that she visits him to say goodbye.

### Key Ideas

- Class and lost opportunity
- Mystery and the supernatural
- Dramatic irony

## Mrs Appleyard and Miss McCraw

Mrs Appleyard relies on Miss McCraw as the embodiment of reason and order. That the most rational person in the film is 'spirited away' shakes Mrs Appleyard's belief that the world can be controlled.

### Key Quotes

- *Mrs Appleyard:* She had come to 'depend so much on Greta McCraw' and her 'masculine intellect'.
- *Mrs Appleyard:* 'How could she allow herself to be spirited away?'

### Key Ideas

- The limits of reason
- Dependence and control

## Mademoiselle and Miss Lumley

The two junior teachers are visual opposites: Mademoiselle wears lace, pearls and softly waving hair, while Miss Lumley wears plaid, spectacles and muddy colours. Mademoiselle goes to the picnic; Miss Lumley, like Sara, is left behind. Mademoiselle has the courage to stand up to Mrs Appleyard and stays to the end; Miss Lumley is too afraid until she finally resigns.

### Key Quotes

- *Miss Lumley:* Irma's discovery is 'wonderful news'.
- *Mademoiselle:* Irma is 'prettier than ever'.

### Key Ideas

- Appearance versus reality
- Fear of authority
- Curiosity and the need for answers

### Appearances Are Deceiving

In many ways the two women are presented as opposites, and it is easy to typecast them: Mademoiselle is glamorous, French and sympathetic to the girls; Miss Lumley defers to Mrs Appleyard, is unfashionable, wears spectacles and is a little afraid of the girls. But Weir makes both more complicated than they appear.

**Costume:** Mademoiselle wears lace blouses, frills and bows, pearls, gently waving hair, lace gloves and flowers and ribbons on her hats; Miss Lumley wears plaid, simple printed blouses, spectacles, muddy colours and mousy hair. Vocabulary: *elegant, graceful, chic, romantic, charming, tastefully adorned, embellished, innocent* (Mademoiselle); *dowdy, prim, sensible, muted, utilitarian, respectable* (Miss Lumley). Phrases for analysis: *emotionally perceptive, harmonious with nature, in touch with innocence and girlhood, connected with the natural world, graceful and nurturing, dreamlike and ethereal*; *well organised and disciplined, strict and conservative, accepting of her role in the social hierarchy, emotionally restrained, respectful of societal conventions, rule-bound and dutiful*.

| | Miss Lumley | Mademoiselle |
|---|---|---|
| **Beginning** | Is aligned with Sara, because neither is allowed to go to the picnic. | Goes to the picnic. Compares Miranda to a work of art. |
| **Middle** | Tells Mrs Appleyard that it is 'wonderful news' that Irma is found; is clearly frightened when chastised; believes the other girls will be found. | Presses Edith to remember what happened, at her bedside and on the Rock; gives the police one of Miranda's garments for the sniffer dogs; is disappointed when only Irma is found; hugs Irma, tells her she is 'prettier than ever', but questions her about what she told the police. |
| **End** | Is frightened by the girls' wild behaviour towards Irma and cowers behind the piano; protests that she tied Sara up 'for her own good'; quits. | Brings Irma back to the school and leaves her with the class; shouts at Edith and slaps her; stays at Appleyard College to the end, listening to Mrs Appleyard at the dinner table. |

**What motivates them?** Statements to weigh up: Miss Lumley is motivated by a desire to obey her headmistress and do a good job; Mademoiselle wants to be liked and admired by the students; while Mademoiselle appears to want the best for the students, she is ultimately driven by her own interests; Miss Lumley is driven by fear of Mrs Appleyard's authority, although she can understand that some of her behaviour is wrong; Miss Lumley would like to appear rational and dutiful but is actually driven by emotions and fear.

**Topic sentence to develop:** *Throughout the film, Weir demonstrates that people often act according to their own emotional needs, even when they appear to be acting rationally or professionally.*

## Irma and the Other Girls

When Irma returns, the girls who once envied and admired her surround her in the gymnasium demanding 'Tell us, Irma!'. Her vivid red dress sets her apart from their white uniforms. The scene turns into a frightening display of mob behaviour, showing how quickly civilised behaviour collapses when people are desperate for answers.

### Key Ideas

- Mass hysteria and mob mentality
- The desire for certainty
- The collapse of civility

The sequences below follow the order of the film. Use them to locate evidence quickly; the Analysis notes suggest how each sequence connects to the big ideas.

## Sequence 1 : The Opening

Summary : Hanging Rock emerges from mist while Miranda's voice-over says 'What we see and what we seem are but a dream, a dream within a dream.' A title card gives precise factual details about the disappearance. Appleyard College is then shown framed against a foreground of wild summer grass.

Analysis : The order is significant. We see the Rock first, then the facts, then the college. From the outset Weir establishes the three forces of the film: nature as a fundamental force, the human need for factual order, and civilisation. The facts tell us what happened but not why, so the film begins with the mystery already unsolved.

## Sequence 2 : St Valentine's Morning

Summary : The girls dress, lace each other's corsets, and exchange Valentine cards and poems. Miranda and Sara share a tender moment. Flowers are everywhere. Mrs Appleyard addresses the girls about gloves, snakes, 'tomboy foolishness' and returning 'at about 8'. Sara is told she is not to go on the picnic.

Analysis : Weir portrays the students as elegant, refined and innocent, but also sheltered, uniform and restrained. The cultivated flowers represent a version of nature that has been domesticated and controlled. Mrs Appleyard's warnings reveal an institutional fear of disorder, danger and lost time.

## Sequence 3 : The Picnic

Summary : The drag, driven by Mr Hussey, carries the girls, Miss McCraw and Mademoiselle to the Rock. Miranda opens a gate to let the party through. The picnic is laid out with cake, china and white dresses. Nearby, Colonel and Mrs Fitzhubert picnic with their nephew Michael and their groom Albert. Mr Hussey's and Miss McCraw's watches are found stopped at twelve. Much of the party grows drowsy and falls asleep.

Analysis : The picnic and the characters' clothing appear incongruous against the ancient landscape; civilised behaviour seems intrusive or strangely detached from the wilderness. The gate is the first threshold between the familiar world and the unknown. The stopped watches signal that the Rock operates outside measured, human time.

## Sequence 4 : The Climb

Summary : Miranda, Marion, Irma and Edith get permission to take measurements at the base of the Rock. Michael watches them cross the stream; Albert makes crude remarks. The girls climb higher, the rocks becoming increasingly maze-like. Near the top they fall asleep, then wake. Miranda, Marion and Irma, now without shoes and stockings, walk between two great rocks. Edith screams and runs back down. Miss McCraw is seen climbing alone.

Analysis : Successive thresholds (the gate, the stream, the narrowing passages) create the sense that the Rock is drawing the girls towards it. Miranda's line that 'everything begins and ends at exactly the right time and place' suggests acceptance of a different kind of time, while Edith's 'when are we going home?' clings to ordinary chronology. Shedding clothes signals liberation from social convention.

## Sequence 5 : The Return of the Drag

Summary : The drag arrives back at the college late at night. Mrs Appleyard, who has been waiting, hears from Mr Hussey that ‘no one knows… We were asleep.’

Analysis : The schedule Mrs Appleyard imposed has collapsed. Mr Hussey’s admission that everyone was asleep suggests that the rational, conscious mind was absent at the very moment of the event, an early sign that reason will not provide an answer.

## Sequence 6 : The Investigation

Summary : Sergeant Bumpher leads the inquiry. Edith is examined by the doctor and asked ‘Was there a man?’ Mrs Bumpher reports that the town believes ‘it couldn’t be local.’ Michael first says he saw three girls, then four. Asked what he was thinking of as the girls crossed the creek, he points to a swan vase. Edith returns to the Rock and remembers a red cloud and Miss McCraw climbing in her drawers; Bumpher fixates on the missing skirt. Search parties, a tracker and dogs comb the Rock.

Analysis : Each line of inquiry looks for an explanation that fits society’s assumptions: a male attacker, an outsider, a sexual crime. Memory proves unreliable. Bumpher’s dismissal of the red cloud shows that the authorities seek only the kind of explanation that fits their worldview. The film suggests rational thinking can be more concerned with preserving a sense of control than with discovering the truth.

## Sequence 7 : Michael’s Search

Summary : Against Albert’s advice, Michael rides to the Rock and searches alone, staying overnight. He becomes disoriented, struggles to climb and falls asleep. Albert finds him dazed and injured, clutching a scrap of lace. Following Michael’s trail, Albert discovers Irma alive.

Analysis : Michael succeeds where the official searches failed, perhaps because he is guided by emotion and intuition rather than logic. Yet the Rock also overwhelms him, rewarding curiosity while frustrating the desire for certainty.

## Sequence 8 : Irma Recovers

Summary : Irma recuperates at the Fitzhuberts’ home, shrouded beneath white gauzy fabric. The doctor tells Bumpher her condition is ‘very strange.’ She cannot remember what happened. The townspeople gather, demanding ‘we’ve got a bloody right to know.’ At the college, Miss Lumley calls the news ‘wonderful’; Mrs Appleyard says it ‘makes it worse.’

Analysis : Irma's return should solve the mystery but instead deepens it. Her lost memory denies rational explanation even to someone who was there. Mrs Appleyard's reaction reveals her real priority: one survivor with no story is worse for the college than a clear answer of any kind.

## Sequence 9 : 'Tell Us, Irma!'

Summary : Before leaving for Europe, Irma visits the college in a vivid red dress. In the gymnasium, where Sara has been strapped to the wall to cure her stooping, the girls surround Irma demanding answers. The scene becomes hysterical; Miss Lumley cowers behind the piano and Mademoiselle intervenes, slapping Edith.

Analysis : Irma's red links her to the red cloud and suggests she has been transformed. The scene exposes the breakdown of social conventions: fear of the unknown and desperation for answers turn the 'refined' young ladies into a mob. Sara's literal restraint is a stark image of the college's oppressive control.

## Sequence 10 : The College Unravels

Summary : Parents withdraw their daughters. Miss Lumley resigns. Mrs Appleyard drinks alone and tells Sara she must return to the orphanage. Sara is later found dead in the greenhouse by the head gardener. That night Albert dreams of his 'kid sister'. Mrs Appleyard tells Mademoiselle that Sara's guardian collected her.

Analysis : The greatest damage comes not from the Rock but from within the institution. Mrs Appleyard's need for control turns into cruelty, and the most vulnerable person pays for it. Her lie about Sara shows her preserving appearances to the end.

## Sequence 11 : The Ending

Summary : At dinner, Mrs Appleyard, dressed more softly than ever before, reminisces about Bournemouth, where 'nothing changed – ever,' and wonders how Miss McCraw could 'allow herself to be spirited away.' A final voice-over reports that the searches continued without result and that Mrs Appleyard died 'while attempting to climb the rock.' The film closes on slow-motion images of the picnic, with Miranda turning to wave.

Analysis : Mrs Appleyard, the film's champion of order, is finally drawn to the Rock herself. Her dishevelled hair and black mourning clothes contrast with her immaculate appearance at the start. The closing return to the picnic, filmed to resemble old footage, leaves the audience

suspended in the moment before the disappearance, and suggests that nature is timeless while society can be disrupted and destroyed.

Use this grid when you plan a Section A essay. Find the idea in the topic, read down the column, and choose the sequences where it is central for your main evidence. The sequence numbers match the Scene Summaries and Analyses page, and the evidence under the grid shows where to look.

**Key:** •• = central to the sequence; • = present and usable; blank = not a strong choice for that idea.

| Sequence | Nature | Reason | Time | Class | Appearance | Restraint |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1. The Opening | •• | • | • | • | • | |
| 2. St Valentine's Morning | • | •• | • | •• | •• | •• |
| 3. The Picnic | •• | • | •• | •• | • | • |
| 4. The Climb | •• | • | •• | • | • | •• |
| 5. The Return of the Drag | | •• | • | | | |
| 6. The Investigation | • | •• | | • | | •• |
| 7. Michael's Search | •• | • | | • | | • |
| 8. Irma Recovers | • | •• | | • | •• | • |
| 9. 'Tell Us, Irma!' | | • | | •• | •• | •• |
| 10. The College Unravels | • | • | | •• | • | • |
| 11. The Ending | •• | • | •• | • | • | • |

**Column headings:** *Nature* = nature as a fundamental force; *Reason* = the human need for rationality and control; *Time* = time, measured and timeless; *Class* = class and civilisation; *Appearance* = beauty, innocence and appearance; *Restraint* = femininity, restraint and release. The first five match the Thematic Quote Bank; the sixth draws on the Values page.

## Nature as a Fundamental Force

**Central:** 1, 3, 4, 7, 11.

- 1: the Rock emerges from the mist before we see the college, and Miranda's voice-over says 'What we see and what we seem are but a dream, a dream within a dream.'
- 3: Irma, as the Rock comes into view: 'Waiting a million years, just for us.'
- 4: the narrowing passages draw the girls upward; Edith: 'Why can't we just sit on this log and look at the ugly old rock from here?'
- 7: the Rock overwhelms Michael, who is found dazed and injured, clutching a scrap of lace.
- 11: Mrs Appleyard, the champion of order, is found at the base of the Rock; the voice-over says 'she fell while attempting to climb the rock'.
- **Present:** the cultivated flowers of Sequence 2; Edith's memory of a red cloud in 6; Michael's 'It comes back at night in dreams'; Albert's dream of Sara in 10.

## The Human Need for Rationality and Control

**Central:** 2, 5, 6, 8.

- 2: Mrs Appleyard's warnings about gloves, snakes and 'tomboy foolishness'.
- 5: Mr Hussey: 'No one knows. No one saw her leave. We were asleep.'
- 6: Sergeant Bumpher asks Edith, 'Was there a man?'; Mrs Bumpher insists, 'People just don't disappear, my dear. Not without good reason.'
- 8: the doctor finds Irma's condition 'very strange', and the townspeople shout, 'We've got a bloody right to know.'
- **Present:** Miss McCraw's 'Must be something magnetic' (3); Marion's measurements (4); Michael's intuition against Albert's advice (7); the girls' demand for answers (9); Mrs Appleyard's grip on the college (10); her question about Miss McCraw being 'spirited away' (11).

## Time

**Central:** 3, 4, 11.

- 3: Mr Hussey: 'Blowed if me watch hasn't stopped.' Miss McCraw: 'Never stopped before. Must be something magnetic.' Miranda rejects her watch: 'Can't stand the ticking above my heart.'
- 4: Miranda: 'Everything begins and ends at exactly the right time and place'; Edith: 'When are we going home?'

- 11: Mrs Appleyard remembers Bournemouth, where ‘Nothing changed. Ever.’; the slow-motion closing images hold the picnic in time.
- **Present:** the title card’s exact date (1); Mrs Appleyard’s expectation that the party will be back ‘for a light supper’ (2); the drag’s late return (5).

## Class and Civilisation

**Central:** 2, 3, 9, 10.

- 2: gloves, corsets and rules; Sara is told she cannot go on the picnic.
- 3: cake, china and white dresses laid out beneath the ancient Rock; Miss McCraw: ‘How foolish can human creatures be.’
- 9: the ‘refined’ young ladies become a hysterical mob around Irma.
- 10: parents withdraw their daughters, and Mrs Appleyard tells Sara she will be returned to the orphanage.
- **Present:** the college framed by wild grass (1); Marion’s ‘Like a lot of ants’ from the Rock (4); the town’s ‘It couldn’t be local’ (6); Michael and Albert’s friendship across class (7); Mrs Appleyard’s concern for the college’s name (8); Bournemouth (11).

## Beauty, Innocence and Appearance

**Central:** 2, 8, 9.

- 2: the girls in white, exchanging Valentines; flowers everywhere.
- 8: Irma, shrouded in white gauze; when Mademoiselle visits, she finds her ‘so pale but prettier than ever’.
- 9: Irma returns in a vivid red dress, set against the girls in white.
- **Present:** ‘what we see and what we seem’ (1); white dresses at the picnic (3); Mademoiselle’s ‘Botticelli angel’; Mrs Appleyard’s lie about Sara’s guardian (10); the final wave from Miranda (11).

## Femininity, Restraint and Release

**Central:** 2, 4, 6, 9.

- 2: the girls lace one another’s corsets.

- 4: Miranda, Marion and Irma go on without shoes and stockings.
- 6: the investigation fixates on a man and on Miss McCraw's missing skirt.
- 9: Sara strapped to the gymnasium wall, 'for her own good'.
- **Present:** gloves removed after Woodend (3); the scrap of lace (7); the doctor's examination of Irma (8); Miss Lumley's departure (10); Mrs Appleyard dressed more softly than ever before (11).

## Strong Combinations

- **Nature against civilisation:** 1, 3, 4, 11.
- **The failure of reason:** 5, 6, 8, 9.
- **Time, measured and timeless:** 3, 4, 11.
- **Institutional cruelty:** 2, 9, 10.

Because there is little dialogue or character development in this film, you need to spend most of your time analysing setting, costume, objects, sound and structure. The notes below work through the key elements of the film in order, with evidence, possible interpretations and sentence starters for turning them into analysis.

## The Opening and Closing Scenes

The film opens with a prologue card: *On Saturday 14th February 1900 a party of schoolgirls from Appleyard College picnicked at Hanging Rock near Mt. Macedon in the state of Victoria. During the afternoon several members of the party disappeared without trace…* This statement sets up the central mystery, but it also suggests a historical event, even though the story is invented. The credits then play over the Rock emerging as if from the mists of time, establishing it as a monument to the endurance of nature, all in under a minute and a half. The film ends with a deep voice explaining what happens to Mrs Appleyard and her college, and noting that the missing girls were never found. The final images are quasi-historical footage of the picnic, in disjointed camera work that further suggests the historical 'truth' of the film.

Throughout the film, Weir contrasts human lives with the natural world: humans need to understand, measure and create rules for their lives, but nature is impervious to all of them. The scenes that bookend the film make this contrast clear.

- **The prologue outlining a specific date** implies that humans need to measure and quantify experiences so that they can understand them.
- **Placing the events in a real, geographical space** creates the sense of a real, human tragedy that is recognisable and understandable.
- **The Rock gradually emerging from the mist** hints at the permanence of the natural world, as opposed to the ephemerality of human lives.
- **Clouds passing slowly over the immutable Rock** suggest that nature is timeless and immeasurable against human lives.
- **The final voice-over detailing the fates of the characters** creates the impression of events that can be quantified and understood.
- **The disjointed, quasi-historical style of the final footage** lends the film a reassuring sense of reality in an otherwise mysterious and confusing narrative.
- **The lingering final images of the girls** reinforce the idea that nature is mysterious and unknowable.

### Contrasting the Opening and Closing

The two sequences are similar, but not identical. Some statements describe both; others suit one more than the other. Ideas to sort and compare:

- although people like to think of themselves as separate from nature, they are an integral part of the environment;
- the beauty of nature is reflected in the youthful grace of the girls;
- statements of fact are like natural features: fixed, measurable and knowable;
- human events sit within the natural landscape;
- nature possesses a power that exceeds human control;
- humanity is fragile when contrasted with the strength of nature;
- nature exists outside human understanding;
- nature exposes the limitations of human knowledge;
- knowledge is as stable and reliable as a rock.

**Sentence building:** *The film's framing scenes / In the opening and concluding moments / Both the opening and the closing of the film / The scenes that bookend Weir's film / By framing his film with scenes that… + share / mirror / reflect / echo + the sense that / a concern with / the idea that / the perception of / a view that / an understanding of… + however / yet / despite this / on the other hand / in contrast…*

## Picnicking

It seems the only reason anyone goes to Hanging Rock is to picnic. Michael is there with his aunt and uncle (and Albert, although as a servant he has to eat on his own), and the girls of Appleyard College have their own picnic. Both groups eat in a highly ritualised fashion. Michael and his family gather around a tiny table, sipping tea from cups and saucers and staring into space. The girls offer up a toast to 'St. Valentine' as Miranda ritualistically cuts the cake. All of this says a great deal about the conventions and customs of the time.

Weir deliberately juxtaposes the elements of human civilisation against the ancient bushland. As you watch, look for human objects that seem out of place in the wilderness: the tablecloth, china cups and saucers, the cake, white dresses, parasols, gloves and hats, the drag and its harnessed horses, Mr Hussey's watch.

**Word bank for incongruity:** *are presented as incongruous against / contrast sharply with / appear discordant with / appear at odds with / provide an intrusive presence in / seem strangely detached from + the ancient landscape / this untamed wilderness / the elemental forces of nature / this rugged terrain / this expansive bushland / a world remote from civilisation.*

**Sentence starters:** *As the characters eat…; In the picnicking scenes…; When the characters picnic…; In comparison to the upper-class characters, who eat…, Albert…*

### After the Meal

After they have finished eating, Edith looks at Michael's family and remarks that they 'might be the only living creatures in the whole world'. Weir then focuses on a group of ants who seem to be having their own picnic of the St Valentine's cake. By zooming in on the ants, Weir reminds us that the human picnic is only one small event in a teeming natural world that carries on regardless of it, and that civilisation's rituals are no defence against nature reclaiming what humans leave behind.

Having eaten, the humans show how 'civilised' they are through actions only humans perform:

- Mr Hussey wants to know the time.

- Irma talks about wearing diamonds in the bath.
- Marion asks if she can take measurements of the Rock.
- Miss McCraw reads.
- Mademoiselle compares a human girl to a piece of art.

These actions can be read in several ways: human beings are driven by a desire to make sense of their surroundings; people seek order in an otherwise chaotic world; individuals strive to categorise and define the world around them; the pursuit of knowledge reflects a deep-seated need for control; people feel compelled to shape the unfamiliar into a meaningful pattern.

**Topic sentence to develop:** *Weir's film examines the human impulse to impose a civilised order that is at odds with the natural world.*

**Linking phrases:** *Throughout the picnicking scene...; Weir depicts...; In doing so, Weir demonstrates...; This suggests that...; This implies that...; This is reinforced by...; Furthermore...; Similarly...; In addition...; Weir further emphasises this through...*

## Thresholds

A threshold is a border between two places; a doorway, for example, is a threshold between the inside of a house and the outside world. Thresholds matter in *Picnic at Hanging Rock* because there are two distinct worlds in the film: the civilised, confined and restricted world of Appleyard College, and the wild, transcendent natural world of Hanging Rock. To pass from one world to the other, the girls cross physical thresholds that symbolise their transition from one way of thinking and behaving to another.

- **Threshold:** boundary, transition, barrier between, liminal space, passage from... to..., crossing over from... to..., the demarcation between, entry into a world of..., leaving behind.
- **Civilised world:** sanctioned space, the known, the familiar, order, control, institutional world, safety, routine, obedience.
- **Natural world:** the unknown, wilderness, discovery, freedom, instinct, the primal self, otherness, ungoverned nature, untamed nature.

### The Gate

When the girls arrive at the base of the Rock there is a physical gate they must pass through. The symbol is simple, but Weir adds extra layers of meaning to the action of opening a gate

between two worlds:

- Immediately before the gate scene, Michael and Albert, men from different classes, share a drink.
- Miranda, Irma and Marion, the three girls who go missing, sit at the head of the drag. Miranda leaps from the drag to open the gate.
- Miranda removes her hat, leaving it in the drag, to open the gate.
- Just before Miranda opens the gate, there is a close-up of a decrepit notice board, its bulletins unreadable from age and weathering.
- Immediately after the gate is opened, Miranda sees a group of birds flying through the sky, and the harnessed horses rear and cry out.

**Sentence starters:** *When the schoolgirls first arrive at the base of the Rock, Miranda opens a gate, symbolising…; Weir reinforces the significance of this symbol by…, which highlights…; Moreover…*

### The Stream

When Miranda, Marion, Irma and Edith set out to climb the Rock (which they were warned not to do), they must cross a stream. Albert, watching, makes a crude, sexualised remark about the girls' appearance. Miranda throws a flower into the stream as she crosses, almost like an offering. Weir then provides a close-up of the stream, revealing its murky, organic naturalness. Possible interpretations:

- Miranda's flower offering suggests the girls are not simply crossing water: they are entering a kind of ritual, perhaps even making a pact with the natural world.
- Albert's voyeuristic commentary frames the crossing as a moment of exposure, as if crossing the stream strips away the girls' protection and makes them vulnerable.
- The murkiness of the stream suggests obscured vision, foreshadowing the incomprehensible nature of what is about to occur.
- The doubling of thresholds creates a sense of inevitability, as though the Rock is drawing the girls towards it through successive layers of boundary.

### The Rocks

The final threshold is the rocks themselves. At the top, the girls find not a single rock but an immense series of rocks that have formed into tunnels and passageways. Miranda, Marion and Irma disappear through one such passageway at the end of the scene. Words to describe how Weir presents the rocks: *maze-like, labyrinthine, mysterious, disorienting, enthralling, drawing in, deep, cavernous, immersive, consuming, primordial, magnetic, twisting, spiralling, hypnotic, powerful*; the rocks form a *pathway* or *entrance way*.

**Sentence frame:** *When the girls get to the top, Weir depicts the rocks as… and…, symbolising how they offer a threshold to a world that is…*

## Time Stops

After the picnic, the girls lounge about and one recites Shakespeare's sonnet 'Shall I compare thee to a summer's day', a poem full of references to time: seasons, months, days. At about this point Mr Hussey notices that his watch has stopped. Even though he says they need to be careful of the time, the four girls head up the Rock for the purpose of measuring it. On the Rock they gossip about Sara, and Irma compares her to a 'doomed' baby deer. Then they move in slow motion, taking off their shoes and stockings.

Each character's words reveal an attitude towards time:

- **Miranda:** 'Don't wear it anymore. Can't stand the ticking above my heart.' – she feels constrained by human constructs of time and seeks to escape them.
- **Miss McCraw:** 'Stopped at twelve. Never stopped before. Must be something magnetic.' – she is dependent on time as a scientific construct and searches for a rational cause.
- **Mr Hussey:** 'Well after two, I'd say. We'd better be careful. I promised Mrs Appleyard I'd have you lot back at the college by eight.' – he is compliant towards the conventions and expectations of schedules.
- **Marion:** 'I should like to make a few measurements of the rock if we have time.' – she feels a sense of authority about the measurement and regulation of time.
- **Irma:** 'We'll be back long before tea.' – she is confident, perhaps naively, in the relentless, predictable passage of time.
- **Miranda:** 'Everything begins and ends at exactly the right time and place.' – she is fatalistic about, even acquiescent to, a larger order that blurs temporal boundaries.
- **Edith:** 'When are we going home?' – she is reliant upon institutional order and patterns.

**Attitude vocabulary:** *fatalistic about, constrained by, reflective about, acquiescent to, feel a sense of authority about, dependent on, searching for, compliant towards, have a sense of agency + the relentless passage of time, adherence to human constructs of time, the ephemerality of time, time as a scientific construct, the measurement and regulation of time, a blurring of temporal boundaries, humanity's relationship with time, the conventions and expectations of schedules, a reliance upon institutional order and patterns*.

Miranda's attitude differs from the others: where most characters measure, obey or depend on time, she rejects her watch and accepts that events happen at their 'right time', as though she belongs to nature's timescale rather than the college's.

### Film Techniques and Time

Weir also plays with time through cinematic devices. Action frequently happens in slow motion, suggesting time is not always linear. Compare two short scenes:

- **Miranda crosses the stream (00:23:20–00:23:43):** a young character, outdoors in nature, in slow motion, with ancient-sounding pan pipes in the background.
- **Mrs Appleyard waits (00:34:49–00:35:08):** an old character, indoors, in silence except for the ticking of a clock.

Statements to weigh up:

- Weir explores the tension between Edwardian society's obsession with schedules and the timelessness of the natural world.
- Weir suggests that humanity's need to measure time reflects a broader desire to impose order on an inherently mysterious universe.
- By disrupting conventions of time, Weir reveals the limitations of human understanding and rational thought.
- Weir's film illustrates that time may be fluid or multidimensional, rather than strictly linear.
- While some people live by the constraints of time, Weir demonstrates that others escape these limitations and transcend normal experience.

## Trying to Make Sense of What Happened

The drag returns to Appleyard College without Miranda, Irma, Marion and Miss McCraw. The burning question on Mrs Appleyard's lips is not what has happened but 'Why are they so

late?', which she asks of herself and of Mademoiselle as she steps down from the drag. This highlights a key focus of the authorities in the aftermath: attempting to make rational sense of an irrational situation.

| What someone says or does | What it shows about 'rational' thinking |
|---|---|
| Mr Hussey, the first to give an account, tells Mrs Appleyard and then Sergeant Bumpher: 'No one knows. No one saw her leave. We were asleep.' | Being unconscious or asleep prevents the rational mind from witnessing, so reason is absent at the very moment of the event. |
| Sergeant Bumpher asks Edith 'Was there a man?' and the doctor checks her for evidence of assault. | For the authorities, the most rational explanation of girls disappearing is a male attacker: they look for an answer that fits their assumptions. |
| Mrs Bumpher reports the town's view: 'It couldn't be local... No one around here would do a thing like that.' | According to the community's rational thinking, a threat cannot come from within but must come from outside, because the community needs to believe in its own respectability. |
| Michael tells Sergeant Bumpher he saw three girls climbing the Rock, then recalls that it was four. | Human memory is not rational or reliable, yet it is all the investigation has to work with. |
| Edith, back at the Rock, remembers 'It was a cloud... it was red' and that Miss McCraw was climbing without her skirt, in her drawers. Bumpher ignores the cloud and fixates on the missing skirt. | Bumpher seeks a rational explanation that fits with his existing worldview, dismissing anything inexplicable. |

**Sentence starters:**

- People try to make rational sense of the disappearances in *Picnic at Hanging Rock* by...
- Through various reactions to the disappearances, Weir suggests that people possess a deep psychological need to...
- Bumpher's failure to engage with Edith's revelation about the 'red cloud' portrays how rational society is unable to...
- The film reveals that rational thinking is often less concerned with discovering the truth than preserving a sense of...
- Ultimately, Weir portrays the disappearances as an event that resists rational explanation, exposing the limitations of...

## Costume, Hair and Undress

Because this is a period drama, costume and styling are deeply symbolic. Mrs Appleyard has a towering pompadour, whereas Miranda's hair is long, blonde and naturalistic. The policemen's uniforms have brass buttons, while the workers wear shirt sleeves and waistcoats (not wearing a jacket was almost shockingly casual in Edwardian times). Michael wears a top hat even at a picnic.

### Hair

When the picnic party arrives back at the college, Mademoiselle's hair is different from when she left. Mrs Appleyard descends the stairs with her hair very firmly in place, although later in the film this changes.

- **Miranda:** naturalistic, natural, untamed, romantic, innocent – connecting her to nature and freedom.
- **Mademoiselle:** carefully arranged before the picnic; dishevelled, tangled and in a state of disarray after it – the day at the Rock has loosened the order she brought with her.
- **Mrs Appleyard:** formal, rigid, upright, severe, restrained, carefully arranged – embodying institutional control, until it unravels in her final scenes.

### What Each Group Wears

Watch the scenes from 00:38:14 to 00:45:56 and notice how costume signals class and the conventions that govern each character: gloves, hats and accessories as formal; jewels and watches as signs of wealth; flowers as a connection with nature or the romantic; uniforms as a job or profession; high necks or buttoned-up shirts as formal. Look closely at Mrs Appleyard, Mr Hussey, the policemen, the searchers (the Indigenous tracker wears a red coat), the doctor, Michael and Mademoiselle.

### A State of Undress

Before the girls disappear into the Rock, they take off their shoes and stockings, and Edith reports that Miss McCraw 'was funny' because she was not wearing her skirt. Phrases you could use to interpret this: *free from social constraints, drawn to wilderness, divesting themselves of convention, leaving social order behind, guided by instinct, embracing freedom, celebrating the natural world, returning to a state of nature, immersed in the landscape, connected to a natural order, becoming one with nature, engaging in pagan ritual.*

## Michael's Quest

The film is really three intersecting stories: the missing girls, Mrs Appleyard's victimisation of Sara, and Michael Fitzhubert's personal journey. In this part of the film, Weir suggests that answers to the mystery cannot be found through rational inquiry alone, but through a willingness to be open to the mystery and power of nature. The big question is: **why is Michael the only one who finds a missing girl?**

### A Different Mindset

- Michael followed the girls partly up the Rock on the day they disappeared.
- When Sergeant Bumpher asks 'As the girls were jumping the creek, what were you thinking of?', Michael does not answer in words but points to a swan vase containing a native flower (one of the few times a native cut flower is shown).
- After Michael points to the swan vase, the scene segues to an image of Miranda and then of a real swan.
- Michael says, 'I wake up every night in a cold sweat. Just wondering if they're still alive.'
- Albert believes that if 'the bloody cop and the bloody… tracker and the bloody dog can't find 'em, well, no one bloody can.' But Michael believes 'they may be out there dying of thirst.'

This evidence supports several readings: Michael is guided by emotion rather than logic; he feels a spiritual or mystical connection to Miranda; he is less constrained by conventional society; he has developed a personal connection to the landscape; his youthful imagination lets him see possibilities others cannot; he is undertaking his own journey of self-discovery.

### An Individual Search

While most characters have given up on finding the girls, Michael cannot let the mystery go.

- On the first day he searches with Albert and they find nothing. He leaves a trail of note paper to show where he has searched – a rational method.
- He decides to spend the night on the Rock, sending Albert home to tell his uncle he is staying the night in Woodend. There is an orange-red, mystical sunset.
- The next day he searches alone.
- At the top of the Rock he falls asleep, and we hear the voices of the girls describing the Rock from earlier in the film.

Words for analysis: *undergoes a..., open to..., driven by emotions of..., moves beyond, reflects the nature of..., drawn to..., personal, crosses a threshold by..., enters a different..., guided by, attuned, receptive to.*

**Sentence frame:** *Weir suggests that Michael succeeds in finding one of the girls where others fail because...*

## Irma Returns

After Albert rescues Michael, he rushes back to the Rock to find the source of the white lace fragment Michael handed him, and finds Irma. At first he is wary, thinking she must be dead, but after nudging her he realises she is alive. Everyone should be delighted, but the discovery unsettles them, because it raises more questions. Where are the others? How did the searchers miss Irma? Why was she not dead after a week on the Rock? As the doctor says: 'Remarkable.'

### Writing About Mystery

Evidence from quotes and cinematography:

- When Albert finds Irma there is an eerie sound of wind rushing through the Rock.
- As the news spreads, the townspeople gather to find answers or renew the search.
- Outside Bumpher's house, a man shouts, 'We've got a bloody right to know.'
- Mrs Appleyard tells her students they can 'thank the Lord for this merciful deliverance of our dear classmate Irma'.
- Mrs Appleyard chides Miss Lumley, saying that 'this makes it worse'.
- Irma recuperates shrouded beneath white, gauzy fabric.
- As the doctor lists Irma's injuries, he tells Bumpher that her unmarked feet are 'very strange'.
- The head gardener says that 'there's some questions got answers and some haven't'.

**Analytic phrases:** *evokes a sense of, suggests, highlights how, demonstrates, imbues the scene with, reveals, elicits the feeling of, signals, implies, examines, accentuates, brings into focus.*

**Mystery phrases:** *resistant to definitive explanations, steeped in ambiguity, demand rationality in everyday life, are subject to forces beyond understanding, human understanding has limits, believe that everything can be explained with effort and*

*application, suggestive of forces beyond logic, imbued with a dreamlike uncertainty, veiled from rational explanation, shrouded in mystery, must accept the limits of human comprehension.*

**Practice topic:** *Peter Weir's film explores a world filled with mysteries beyond human understanding. Discuss.* Possible topic sentences:

- Weir suggests that humanity's desire to impose order on the world is ultimately challenged by forces beyond its understanding.
- Weir's film demonstrates that rational explanations are often inadequate when confronted with the mysteries of the natural world.
- *Picnic at Hanging Rock* explores the tension between humanity's need for answers and the existence of mysteries that remain unresolved.
- By surrounding key events with ambiguity, Weir emphasises that complete understanding is often unattainable.
- *Picnic at Hanging Rock* demonstrates the discomfort that people experience when faced with the inexplicable.

**Linking language:** *The film further explores this idea when...; Weir's exploration of... is exemplified by...; The significance of this... is evident in...; Weir reinforces this through...; This idea is visually represented by...; This becomes particularly evident when...; moreover, again, furthermore, likewise, what is more, more profoundly; while, however, yet, even though, although, whereas.*

## Mrs Appleyard's Story

Mrs Appleyard is one of the film's most important characters. She has created the school's ethos and rules, so she represents a form of institutional authority that seeks to organise and control the lives of women. Her status and reputation depend on how the girls present themselves to the world. When the girls disappear under mysterious circumstances, and evidence emerges that their corsets and clothing had been removed, her standing as a figure of authority, respectability and decorum is irreparably damaged. She is ultimately a tragic figure: like many tragic characters she cannot bend or adapt, clinging desperately to social status, order and control. This rigidity leads to her downfall. She dies, apparently, 'while attempting to climb the rock', the natural force that challenged her belief in human order and exposed the limits of her authority.

### Mrs Appleyard's Nature

- Her formal, ornate and old-fashioned hairstyle.
- The watch she wears pinned to her chest.
- Most of her interactions with others involve reminding them of the rules.
- Her unsympathetic interactions with Sara Waybourne.
- Her dark clothing and black dresses.
- In the second half of the film, she wears a brooch with a photograph of her husband.
- Her belief that finding 'only one' girl 'makes it worse'.
- Her insistence that Appleyard College is not a 'charitable institution'.
- She is typically shown at her desk, standing higher than other characters, or in an over-the-shoulder shot.
- The dinner where she remembers the good old days at Bournemouth, when 'nothing changed – ever'.

**Vocabulary:** *authoritarian, controlling, representative of institutional authority, strict, fragile, fearful of disorder, inflexible, rigid, elitist, lonely, conventional, rule-bound, cold, distant*.

**Sentence frames:** *Weir depicts Mrs Appleyard's... nature through...; Weir creates a portrait of Mrs Appleyard as... and... by...*

### Mrs Appleyard's Setting

Weir conveys Mrs Appleyard not only through what she wears and how she behaves, but through the spaces she occupies, chiefly her study and sometimes her bedroom.

- **The clock that constantly and audibly ticks in her study** conveys her obsession with order, schedules and discipline.
- **The large portrait of Queen Victoria, surrounded by the English flag, above her desk** represents her need to display her reverence for authority and status.
- **The pictures of her husband and ancestors on her study walls** symbolise her attachment to history and convention.

- **The picture of a tiger on her study wall** illustrates both the power of her authority and hidden emotional depths.

### Mrs Appleyard's End

Because Mrs Appleyard represents institutional authority, the events at the Rock, which challenge human order and certainty, have a profound effect on her.

- On the night before her death, she dines with Mademoiselle de Poitiers, wearing softer, less severe clothing: the only time we see her dressed this way.
- At dinner, she reminisces about annual holidays in Bournemouth with her late husband, describing it as 'a delightful place'.
- She admits she had come to 'depend so much on Greta McCraw' and her 'masculine intellect', wondering, 'How could she allow herself to be spirited away?'
- The final image of her shows her in black mourning clothes and a funeral veil, staring directly into the camera, as we are told she died 'while attempting to climb the rock'.

**Question to answer:** What are the consequences of Mrs Appleyard's controlling mindset?

## Unresolved Mysteries

You could write an essay about unresolved mysteries that goes: *There's a rock. It does strange things. End of story*. It would not get a good mark. Instead, consider the evidence for each mystery and weigh up possible interpretations.

### 1. Why Does Irma Return but the Others Stay Missing?

**Evidence:**

- When Miranda says at the picnic that she no longer wears her pretty jewelled watch, Irma says that if it were hers, she would wear it 'always… even in the bath.'
- Before the girls disappear, Irma says to the prone Edith, 'Poor Edith. We'll go back soon.'
- Irma cannot recall what happened to her on the Rock.
- **M**iranda, **M**arion and Miss **M**cCraw are all linked in their names; Irma is different.
- When Irma revisits Appleyard College, she wears a vivid red dress. The cloud Edith saw at the Rock was red.

**Possible interpretations:** Irma belongs more to the world of civilisation than to the mysterious world of nature; Irma belongs to both worlds; one girl returning heightens the mystery and uncertainty of what happened to the others, a reminder that some mysteries can never be solved; nature allows no rational explanation of its mysteries, even to those who experienced them; Irma has been transformed by her experiences on the Rock, offering a glimpse of what might have happened to the other girls.

### 2. Why Does the Rock Affect People Differently?

**Evidence:**

- On the day of the picnic, many characters at the Rock (including Michael's uncle and aunt) are overcome by sleepiness.
- While Miranda, Marion and Irma are drawn to the Rock, Edith finds it 'nasty'.
- Michael and Albert remain unaffected by the sleepiness that overtakes others on the day of the picnic.
- When Edith returns to the Rock with Sergeant Bumpher and Mademoiselle, she seems unaffected by its mysterious power.
- When Bumpher and the first search party climb the Rock, they stop halfway, overcome by heat and exhaustion.
- When Michael searches the Rock alone, he becomes disoriented, struggles to climb and eventually falls asleep.
- After Irma returns, the final search shows the party gathered at the base of the Rock in a relaxed, almost picnic-like atmosphere.

**Possible interpretations:** the more people attempt to investigate and control the mysteries of the Rock, the more it resists them; the Rock's power is shaped by each person's willingness, or inability, to embrace the unknown; those who approach the Rock with openness are more receptive to its power; the Rock invites people to abandon the constraints of civilisation and enter a timeless world; the Rock reveals people's true nature rather than affecting everyone the same way; it rewards curiosity but frustrates the desire for certainty; its power cannot be predicted or explained by human logic.

### 3. What Happened to Sara?

Weir creates a trail of deliberately conflicting clues about Sara's fate.

- Before Mrs Appleyard sees Sara for the last time, Sara sits on her bed beneath a painting of a woman holding two babies, repeating to herself, 'This is not a charitable institution.'
- Mrs Appleyard tells Mademoiselle that Sara's guardian has come to collect her, though this appears not to have happened. In their final meeting she instead tells Sara, 'You will be returned to the orphanage.'
- Immediately after this, we see luggage being packed into a carriage, although it later becomes clear this is happening at Michael's house.
- After her final meeting with Mrs Appleyard, Sara smiles to herself with an expression of quiet resolution.
- On the night of Sara's death, Albert dreams of his sister, who tells him, 'I've come a long way to see ya, and now I must go.'

**Possible interpretations:** Mrs Appleyard drives Sara to end her own life; Mrs Appleyard murders Sara; Sara's fate mirrors the disappearances, suggesting the Rock's influence extends beyond the landscape; the search for certainty about Sara's death is as futile as the search for the missing girls; Sara's fate shows that human actions in 'civilisation' are just as mysterious as nature; Sara escapes institutional control only through death.

### 4. What Happened to Mrs Appleyard?

**Evidence:**

- In her final scene, Mrs Appleyard wears mourning clothes, as though grieving the loss of her school, her reputation or even herself.
- In her final scene, she wears an expression of quiet resolve, echoing Sara's demeanour before her death.
- She admits she had come to 'depend' on Miss McCraw and cannot understand how her masculine intellect could be 'spirited away… like a silly schoolgirl.'

**Possible interpretations:** Mrs Appleyard confronts the mysterious power of the Rock and is overwhelmed by it; she is seeking answers at the Rock; she is unhappy with her status and identity and seeks transformation on the Rock; by climbing the Rock herself, she abandons the ordered world she spent her life defending.

**Activity:** Arrange the four mysteries on a spectrum from *mysterious, unsettling and disturbing* to *makes sense, can be accepted*. Which do you find least and most explicable, and

why?

## Time: Finite and Infinite

Humans measure time in years, months, weeks, days, all the way down to microseconds, as though it gives them control. Most characters measure out their lives, but there are notable exceptions: Miranda has an almost mystical belief that everything happens at 'exactly the right time'. One of Weir's central points is that the natural world has boundless, apparently infinite time, while humans have only a brief, finite time to live.

- **Time as finite and measurable:** 'What time is it?'; the grandfather clock in Mrs Appleyard's study; the regular beat of classical music; 'can't stand the ticking above my heart' (Miranda, of her watch); the date and year at the opening of the film; Minnie and Tom rushing to get dressed because time has got away from them; 'Blowed if me watch hasn't stopped'; 'When are we going home?'; 'I'd wear it always' (Irma, of Miranda's watch); 'We'd better be careful. I promised Mrs Appleyard…'.
- **Time as infinite and endless:** 'Everything begins and ends at exactly the right time and place'; slow-motion filming of Miranda; the thrumming of the Rock; 'What we see and what we seem are but a dream, a dream within a dream'; the haunting pan flutes; the footage of the picnic at the end of the film, simulating the limited frames of historic film; the Rock is 'quite young, geologically speaking'; 'Waiting a million years, just for us'; the girls losing track of time and dancing on top of the Rock; the opening shot of Hanging Rock emerging from mist.

## Organising Evidence for Essays

For each key idea, gather evidence from three areas before you plan. Tick off what you can use, then note quotes, actions or scenes for each.

- **Characters:** Miranda, Marion, Irma, Edith, Sara, Mrs Appleyard, Mademoiselle, Miss McCraw, Michael, Albert, Bumpher.
- **Symbols:** the Rock, thresholds, animals, the swan, flowers, costume, hairstyles, mirrors, watches, clock sounds, contrasting settings.
- **Film techniques:** slow motion, the prologue card, the closing voice-over, pan-pipe music, classical music, thrumming sounds, shrieking sounds, science-fiction-like sounds.

Guiding questions for each idea:

- **Nature as a fundamental force:** how do these elements show that nature is powerful, mysterious, frightening, fascinating or beyond human control?
- **Rationality and control:** how do they show that humans yearn for order and certainty, as opposed to the irrationality and disorder of nature?
- **Class and civilisation:** how do they show aspects of institutions, authorities, social divisions, rules and conventions?
- **Time:** how do they show aspects of time, systems, routines, measurement and cycles?

### A Paragraph Frame

**Topic:** *In Picnic at Hanging Rock, the natural world is unknowable. Discuss.*

- **Topic sentence:** From the beginning of *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, Peter Weir presents the natural world as a mysterious force that can never be fully understood.
- **Initial examples:** In the scene where…, Weir suggests that nature…; Through the use of…, Weir emphasises…; This suggests that the natural world…
- **Link:** Weir further underlines the mystery of the untamed world through…
- **Further examples:** When…, we see that…; By…, Weir illustrates that…
- **Synthesising sentence:** Ultimately, Weir represents the natural realm through these scenes as… and…

A second topic sentence to try: *The majority of human interactions in the wilderness surrounding Hanging Rock illustrate a deep discomfort and unease.*

### Unpacking Topics into Sub-Ideas

**To what extent does *Picnic at Hanging Rock* suggest that the desire to understand the world is ultimately futile?** Brainstorm alternatives for 'understand the world' and 'futile', then choose a sub-idea:

- The film suggests that humanity's search for certainty is ultimately defeated by the enduring mysteries of the natural world.
- Weir portrays the failure of the police investigation as a symbol of the limits of human explanation.

- By refusing to explain the disappearance, Weir challenges the audience's assumption that every mystery has a solution.
- Although the truth remains elusive, the characters' attempts to understand the disappearance expose important truths about themselves and their society.
- While *Picnic at Hanging Rock* denies both its characters and audience definitive answers, it suggests that the search for meaning remains an essential part of the human experience.

**The film suggests that human systems of order collapse when confronted by nature. To what extent do you agree?**

- Throughout *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, Weir presents the natural world as a force that exposes the fragility of human attempts to impose order.
- The disappearance at Hanging Rock reveals how quickly the certainty and structure of society begin to unravel.
- The film portrays institutions of society as ineffective when faced with forces they cannot explain.
- The failure of authority figures throughout the film demonstrates that positions of power offer little protection against nature's influence.
- As the mystery deepens, the carefully maintained appearance of control gradually gives way to confusion, fear and disorder.

**In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, appearances are carefully maintained, but rarely reflect reality. Discuss.** This topic has two parts: appearances are carefully maintained; appearances do not reflect reality. Brainstorm vocabulary and examples for each, then write a paragraph whose first half shows how Weir presents people and settings with carefully maintained appearances, and whose second half shows how these do not reflect reality.

**The greatest threat to order in *Picnic at Hanging Rock* comes not from nature but within society itself. Discuss.** Brainstorm 'threats from nature' against 'greater threats from within society', then write a paragraph responding to each part.

**An essay process for time topics:** circle key words in the topic; brainstorm alternative vocabulary; refer back to your notes and tables to brainstorm examples; sort examples into three or four groups as the basis for body paragraphs; plan the topic sentence for each group; write the essay. Try it on: *Human systems of order are insignificant when confronted by the natural world*; *Picnic at Hanging Rock highlights how nature is timeless and mysterious*; *In*

*Picnic at Hanging Rock*, the order and rules of civilisation are rendered meaningless by the natural world.

## List of Techniques

Film Techniques in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*

| Technique | Definition / Effect | Example in the film |
|---|---|---|
| Extreme long shot | Shows a subject from a great distance, often dwarfed by its surroundings. | The girls appear tiny against the towering pinnacles of the Rock, emphasising human insignificance. |
| Low-angle shot | Camera looks up at a subject, making it seem powerful or threatening. | The Rock is frequently shot from below, so it towers over and dominates the characters. |
| High-angle shot | Camera looks down on a subject, making it seem small or vulnerable. | Marion looks down on the picnickers 'like a lot of ants'; Mrs Appleyard is often positioned above others. |
| Framing | How elements are arranged within the frame to direct attention or suggest relationships. | Characters are enveloped by foliage or enclosed by rock walls, appearing subsumed by nature. |
| Slow motion | Footage played slower than real time, creating a dreamlike or significant effect. | Miranda at the stream and the final picnic images, suggesting a moment outside ordinary time. |
| Soft focus and diffused light | Blurred edges and hazy light that soften the image. | The morning at Appleyard and the picnic glow like paintings, idealising the girls and the bush. |
| Dissolve | One image fades gradually into another, linking them. | Michael's swan vase gives way to Miranda and then to a real swan, linking the three. |
| Voice-over | Narration heard over the images. | Miranda's opening 'dream within a dream'; the closing report of Mrs Appleyard's death. |
| Diegetic sound | Sound that exists within the world of the film. | The ticking of clocks, the thrum of the Rock, cicadas and birdsong. |
| Non-diegetic sound | Sound added for the audience, such as the score. | Zamfir's pan flute and Bruce Smeaton's music over the landscape. |

| Technique | Definition / Effect | Example in the film |
|---|---|---|
| Soundscape | The combination of music, effects and ambient sound that builds atmosphere. | A low rumble and shrieking, insistent noise during the climb create unease. |
| Costume | Clothing used to communicate character, class and ideas. | White muslin, gloves and hats at the college; Irma's red dress on her return; Mrs Appleyard's black mourning clothes. |
| Mise-en-scène | Everything placed in the frame: setting, props, costume, lighting, actors' positions. | Mrs Appleyard's study with its grandfather clock and portrait, signalling order and authority. |
| Symbolic colour | Colour used to carry meaning. | White suggests innocence and conformity; red links Miss McCraw's dress, the red cloud and Irma's return. |
| Cross-cutting | Cutting between two scenes happening at the same time. | Moving between the college and the Rock, or between Sara and Albert on the night of her death. |
| Close-up | Tightly frames a face or object to reveal emotion or detail. | Stopped watches, Miranda's face, Sara's photograph of Miranda. |
| Point-of-view shot | Shows what a character sees. | Michael watching the girls cross the stream; the girls looking up at the Rock. |
| Archival effect | Footage styled to look like old film. | The final picnic images simulate the limited frames of historic film, as if the past is a lost record. |

## Framing the Rock

How Weir frames the Rock is one of the most reusable pieces of evidence in the film. The camera presents the Rock as something that acts on the characters. Useful vocabulary:

- **What the Rock does (verbs):** towers over, dwarfs, encloses, conceals, swallows, lures, beckons, traps, dominates, overwhelms.
- **What the Rock is (nouns):** labyrinth, barrier, gateway, prison, predator, refuge, mystery, force, portal, wilderness.
- **What the Rock is like (adjectives):** towering, ancient, mysterious, claustrophobic, menacing, alluring, hypnotic, overwhelming, otherworldly, unknowable.

- **How characters are framed within nature:** vulnerable, subsumed, enveloped, immersed, diminished, overshadowed.

> *'Through low-angle shots that make the Rock tower over the climbing girls, Weir portrays nature as an ancient, dominating force that dwarfs human ambition.'*

## Sound and Music

The soundtrack is one of Weir's main tools for creating mystery. Notice how each element connects to an idea:

- **Classical music** (such as Beethoven) – the human construct of measurable time and European order imposed on beauty.
- **Pan pipes** – the timelessness and haunting allure of nature; liberation from social convention.
- **The string quartet and parlour music** – the constraints of etiquette and the preservation of social hierarchy.
- **The thrumming of the Rock** – the inexplicable power of the natural world and its ancient rhythms.
- **Shrieking, insistent noise** – human horror and discomfort in the face of the unknowable.
- **Ticking clocks** – humanity's desire to measure, schedule and control.
- **Science-fiction-like beeping** – nature governed by incomprehensible forces; the transcendence of conventional time.

> *'Through the soundtrack, Weir demonstrates that humanity's obsession with measuring time is ultimately pointless when compared with the timelessness of nature.'*

Some of the music has a time signature (like most music you hear), some has a drifting, ethereal time signature (the pan pipes), and some has no time signature at all (the thrumming of the Rock). Music also creates mood. Other connections to consider: people's desire to create structures and societal conventions; the quest for individual identity outside social mores; temporal order imposed on beauty; liberation from social convention; frustration with unanswered questions.

Other topic sentences for a paragraph that refers only to sound:

- The soundtrack of Weir's film underscores how humanity's desire to impose order contrasts with the mysteries of the natural environment.
- Through the soundscape of his film, Weir presents how humans have a limited and incomplete understanding of enigmatic natural forces.
- Through the music of the film, Weir suggests that nature offers liberation from the restrictive expectations of Edwardian society.
- The music and soundscape of *Picnic at Hanging Rock* evoke the timeless rhythms of nature and the artificiality of human structures and conventions.

## Costume

Costume tells us about class, conformity and transformation.

- **The schoolgirls:** white dresses, gloves and hats suggest elegance, innocence and respectability, but also fragility and restraint. Those who climb remove hats, gloves, shoes and stockings; Edith keeps hers on.
- **Mrs Appleyard:** dark, severe dresses, an ornate, old-fashioned hairstyle and a watch pinned to her chest. Later she wears a brooch with her late husband's photograph, and at the end her carefully arranged hair becomes dishevelled.
- **Miss McCraw:** a dark red dress and a veil to keep flies off her face.
- **Mademoiselle:** lace blouses, frills, pearls, lace gloves and softly waving hair – elegant and romantic.
- **Miss Lumley:** plaid, simple printed blouses, spectacles and muddy colours – sensible, muted, utilitarian.
- **Irma's return:** a vivid red dress among the white uniforms, linking her to the red cloud and marking her transformation.
- **Uniforms:** the police, the doctor and the searchers (including the Indigenous tracker in a red coat) are identified by their roles, showing how society organises people by function and class.

| Symbol | Meaning and significance |
|---|---|
| **Hanging Rock** | – Symbolises the power of nature and humanity's attraction to and fear of it<br>– Ancient and unknowable, it exists beyond human understanding, control and time<br>– Represents not only the external natural world but people's inner nature: their instincts, feelings and desires |
| **Watches and Clocks** | – Represent the human need to measure, organise and control time<br>– Miranda rejects her watch; Irma would wear it 'always'; Hussey's and McCraw's watches stop at twelve<br>– Mrs Appleyard's pinned watch and the grandfather clock in her study embody institutional order |
| **Flowers** | – Cultivated flowers represent nature domesticated, arranged and controlled by civilisation<br>– Reinforce a European ideal of feminine beauty imposed on the Australian landscape<br>– Contrast with the wild grasses and growth at the Rock; Miranda's flower offering at the stream suggests a pact with nature<br>– Many girls carry red roses on the way to the St Valentine's picnic; Irma wears a robe with floral emblems when Mademoiselle visits her; her red hat on her return looks like a red rose<br>– Albert's dream of his sister comes with the 'strong' smell of pansies; in Mrs Appleyard's final scene, a white rose sits on her desk |
| **Thresholds: the Gate, the Stream, the Rocks** | – Each marks a crossing from the familiar, sanctioned world into the unknown<br>– The murky stream suggests obscured vision and foreshadows the incomprehensible<br>– The doubling of thresholds creates a sense of inevitability, as if the Rock is drawing the girls in |
| **The Swan** | – Associated with Miranda through Michael's swan vase and the dissolve to a real swan<br>– Like the 'Botticelli angel', suggests grace, purity and something otherworldly<br>– Represents Michael's romantic, intuitive connection to Miranda and the natural world<br>– A white swan glides on the water twice and appears beside Michael's bed once; only Michael sees it, and in its final appearance it flies away off-screen |
| **Animals** | – The world of the Rock features ants, cicadas, lizards and snakes: strange, ancient and beyond control<br>– The world of civilisation features horses, dogs and turkeys: tame, obedient and |

| Symbol | Meaning and significance |
| --- | --- |
| | dependent<br>– Marion's comparison of people to 'a lot of ants' reverses the hierarchy, making humans seem insignificant |
| **The Colour Red** | – Miss McCraw's dark red dress, the red cloud Edith remembers, and Irma's red dress on her return<br>– Suggests danger, passion and transformation in contrast to the white of innocence and conformity |
| **Clothing: Corsets, Gloves and Stockings** | – Symbolise the restraint society places on young women<br>– Removing them on the Rock signals liberation; Irma's missing clothing becomes an obsession for the investigators |
| **The Botticelli Angel** | – Mademoiselle's comparison idealises Miranda as a work of art: beautiful, pure, and not quite of this world<br>– Shows how the characters see Miranda through European cultural ideals rather than as she is |
| **Mirrors** | – Miranda is first seen combing her hair at a table, her reflection shown in multiple mirrors<br>– When Mademoiselle first speaks to Irma after her return, Irma is initially shown as a blurred reflection in a mirror<br>– Near the end, Mrs Appleyard combs her hair while looking mournfully into a mirror<br>– Suggest the quest for identity: reflecting, examining and confronting the self; more than one identity; hidden feelings |
| **Dreams** | – Michael dreams of the Rock; Albert dreams of his sister on the night of her death<br>– Disconnected from the rational mind, dreams suggest connections between people and nature that transcend logic |
| **Mrs Appleyard's Study** | – Its clock, desk and portrait of her husband represent authority, order and the past<br>– As events spiral, it becomes a place of drinking and isolation, symbolising the collapse of her control |

## Linking a Symbol to a Key Idea

A model, using vocabulary from the notes on mirrors:

> *Throughout Picnic at Hanging Rock, Weir emphasises the quest for identity through the symbolism of mirrors. By repeatedly showing characters* ***examining*** *themselves*

> *in mirrors, Weir suggests that identity is something that must be **confronted** rather than simply accepted. At the very beginning of the film, Miranda is first shown sitting at a table combing her hair, her reflection appearing in multiple mirrors to suggest that her **sense of self** cannot be reduced to or **confined** by a single definition.*

Try the same with animals (*strange, safe, familiar, obedient, ancient, threatening, beyond control, untameable, tame, dependent*), flowers (*transformation, romance, loss, beauty, youth, innocence, fragility, the domestic world, ephemerality, the passing of time, refinement, transience, grief, death, connection to emotions, civilisation, respectability, the ordered natural world, traditional femininity*) and the swan (*idealisation, transformation, purity, of the natural world, dreamlike quality, transcendence, serenity, conventional beauty, unattainable, beyond the human world, out of reach, freedom*).

Select a highlighted passage to see what earns marks in that moment. Use the buttons to show one category at a time.

## Sample 1: Model *Picnic at Hanging Rock* Essay

Topic: **How does Weir depict the natural world as a source of both fascination and fear?**

*Introduction*

In *Picnic at Hanging Rock* (1975), Peter Weir constructs the Australian bush as a place that draws people in at the very moment it threatens to consume them. Through his framing of the ancient Rock, his treatment of time and the haunting soundscape of the film, Weir presents a landscape that is at once enchanting and menacing to the members of colonial society who visit it. Ultimately, the film suggests that nature's allure and its danger come from the same source: it lies beyond the reach of human understanding and control.

*Body Paragraph 1*

From the opening sequence, Weir establishes the Rock as an alluring yet ominous presence that overshadows the civilised world. The film begins not with Appleyard College but with the Rock emerging slowly from mist, accompanied by Miranda's voice-over: 'what we see and what we seem are but a dream, a dream within a dream.' By placing the Rock first, before the factual title card and the image of the college, Weir signals that nature is the primary force in the film, older and more powerful than the society that tries to explain it. As the girls climb, low-angle shots make the pinnacles tower over them, while narrow passages enclose them in a labyrinth of stone. The girls are enthralled, gazing upwards as if hypnotised, yet the same

framing diminishes them, rendering them vulnerable within a landscape that seems to be swallowing them. Through this framing, Weir positions viewers to share the girls' fascination while sensing the threat they cannot see. This is how the film makes nature's allure and its danger inseparable.

*Body Paragraph 2*

Weir further portrays nature as captivating and frightening by showing that it operates outside the measured, human time on which civilisation depends. Mrs Appleyard's instruction to return 'at about 8' and Irma's confidence that they will be back 'long before tea' reflect a society organised by schedules. At the Rock, however, these certainties dissolve: Mr Hussey's and Miss McCraw's watches stop at twelve, and Miss McCraw can only speculate that there 'must be something magnetic.' For Miranda, this escape from clock time is liberating. She cannot 'stand the ticking above [her] heart' and, at the summit, declares that 'everything begins and ends at exactly the right time and place.' For Edith, by contrast, the loss of ordinary time is terrifying, as her repeated plea, 'when are we going home?', reveals. Weir thus shows that the timelessness of nature is fascinating to those willing to surrender to it and frightening to those who cling to human order.

*Body Paragraph 3*

The soundscape of the film reinforces this duality, making the bush seem both enchanting and unsettling. Gheorghe Zamfir's pan flute drifts over images of the girls crossing the stream, imbuing the landscape with an ethereal, romantic beauty and associating it with freedom from the restrictions of the college. Yet beneath this music Weir layers a low, insistent rumble that seems to emanate from the Rock itself, and as Edith flees, her screams merge with a shrieking, discordant noise. These sounds destabilise the idyllic images and evoke a sense of forces beyond human comprehension. Even after Irma is found, an eerie rush of wind through the rocks suggests that nature's mystery remains intact. Through this contrast between seductive melody and menacing sound, Weir ensures that the audience never fully trusts the beauty of the bush.

*Conclusion*

Weir's *Picnic at Hanging Rock* depicts the natural world as a source of fascination precisely because it is a source of fear. Through framing that dwarfs the characters, a treatment of time that defies human measurement and a soundscape that blends beauty with menace, Weir presents a landscape that invites surrender while threatening destruction. In refusing to explain the disappearance, the film leaves its audience in the same position as its characters: drawn to a mystery that cannot be solved.

## Sample 2: Paragraph Rewrite

Topic: **In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, the passing of time deepens rather than resolves the mystery of the girls' disappearance. Discuss.**

*Original paragraph (does not fully respond to the topic)*

Irma's return provides hope that the mystery of the other girls' disappearance might eventually be solved. When Irma is found, the townspeople gather together to find answers and renew the search. One man even shouts, 'we've got a bloody right to know,' showing that people are still determined to discover what happened. However, Irma cannot remember what happened to her on the Rock. The doctor also describes Irma's condition as 'very strange,' while Mrs Appleyard says that her return 'makes it worse.' These examples show that Irma's return does not solve the mystery and that the characters still have lots of unanswered questions.

*What is wrong with it?*

- The topic sentence argues the opposite of the topic (hope of resolution) and never mentions time.
- It shows that questions remain unanswered, but not how Irma's return creates *new* questions.
- It does not explain why Mrs Appleyard says Irma's return 'makes it worse'.
- It ends by summarising events rather than making a larger point about Weir's message.

*Rewritten paragraph*

Rather than bringing the investigation closer to the truth, Irma's return a week after the picnic only multiplies the questions surrounding the disappearance. As news spreads, the townspeople gather outside Bumpher's house, and one man's insistence that 'we've got a bloody right to know' reveals a community that assumes time and effort will inevitably produce answers. Yet Irma cannot remember what happened on the Rock, and the doctor's verdict that her condition is 'very strange' turns the one surviving witness into a fresh mystery. Mrs Appleyard's response, that the discovery 'makes it worse', is telling: a single survivor with no story removes the possibility of a simple ending, leaving the fate of the others more uncertain than before. Weir underscores this as Irma recuperates shrouded beneath white gauze, an image that veils her as completely as the mist veils the Rock. Through Irma's return, Weir suggests that the passage of time does not erode a mystery but entrenches it, exposing the limits of a society that believes everything can be explained.

## Sample 3: Essay Plan

Topic: **How does Weir explore the relationship between knowledge and control in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?**

This topic has two ideas, and both must be addressed. You might show how characters are motivated more by one than the other, how the desire for one leads to the other, or how the two come into conflict.

*Contention*

Weir suggests that characters seek knowledge in order to gain control, but that the Rock exposes the limits of both, forcing them to confront a world that cannot be understood or mastered.

*BP1: People initially seek knowledge as a way of gaining control over the world.*

- Miss McCraw studies the Rock through geometry and geology – she tries to understand nature through measurement and logic.
- Marion wants to 'make a few measurements of the rock' – knowledge as a way of claiming the landscape.
- Mrs Appleyard's warnings about snakes, ants and 'tomboy foolishness' – knowing the dangers in advance is meant to keep the girls safe and controlled.
- Sergeant Bumpher questions witnesses ('Was there a man?') – seeks a rational explanation that will restore order.

*BP2: Weir shows that attempts to gain knowledge often reveal the limits of human control.*

- Michael changes his memory from three girls to four – memory and perception are unreliable.
- Bumpher dismisses Edith's red cloud and fixates on Miss McCraw's missing skirt – the authorities accept only knowledge that fits their worldview.
- The watches stop at twelve: 'Must be something magnetic' – the instruments of control fail.
- The doctor finds Irma's condition 'very strange' – investigation deepens rather than solves the mystery.

*BP3: Ultimately, people must accept that complete knowledge and control are impossible – and those who cannot accept this are destroyed.*

- Mrs Appleyard says finding only one girl ‘makes it worse’ – uncertainty threatens her need for order.
- Her control turns to cruelty towards Sara, and her college collapses.
- The head gardener: ‘There’s some questions got answers and some haven’t’ – acceptance of uncertainty.
- Mrs Appleyard dies ‘while attempting to climb the rock’ – the champion of control is consumed by what she could not understand.

# Section A Sample Essays: *Picnic at Hanging Rock* (Low, Medium and High)

Topic: **Weir suggests that the order imposed by Appleyard College cannot contain the natural world. To what extent do you agree?**
*Sample Essay I (Low)*

*Introduction*

In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, Peter Weir shows a school trying to control nature and failing. I agree with the statement because the college’s rules, its clocks and its sounds all break down when the girls go to the Rock. Weir uses setting, time and sound to show this.
*Body Paragraph 1*

Weir shows that the college’s rules mean little against the power of nature. Mrs Appleyard has many rules for the picnic. She tells the girls to return ‘at about 8’ and warns them about snakes. This shows the college wants to control the girls. However, when they get to the Rock the rules do not work anymore because the Rock is very big. Weir shows the Rock in big shots so it looks powerful.
*Body Paragraph 2* The rules meant to protect the girls are the first thing the Rock overrides.

Time is another way the college tries to control things. Mr Hussey’s and Miss McCraw’s watches stop at twelve, and Miss McCraw says it ‘must be something magnetic’. This shows the Rock is stronger than the clocks. Irma says they will be back ‘long before tea’, but they never come back, so the college’s plans fail.
*Body Paragraph 3* So the order the college relies on fails at the very point it is meant to hold.

Weir's soundtrack makes nature seem both beautiful and dangerous. The music is calm at first, then there is a scary noise. This shows nature is beautiful but also dangerous. When Edith runs, she screams, which makes the audience feel scared.
*Conclusion* The threat of the Rock is therefore something the audience hears as well as sees.

Weir shows the college trying to control nature and failing. The rules, the time and the sound all show this. Therefore I agree with the statement.
*Sample Essay II (Medium)*

*Introduction*

In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, Peter Weir presents Appleyard College as a place built on order: its timetables, its rules about gloves and punctuality, its certainty about when the girls will return. I agree that the film shows this order failing against nature, though the failure is not a simple victory for the Rock. Weir uses time, framing and sound to show an ordered world losing its hold on the people inside it.
*Body Paragraph 1*

The college lives by the clock, and the picnic is planned around it . Mrs Appleyard tells the girls to return 'at about 8', and Irma is confident they will be back 'long before tea'. At the Rock, though, the clocks stop. Mr Hussey's and Miss McCraw's watches stop at twelve, and Miss McCraw can only suggest that it 'must be something magnetic'. The mechanical measures of the college become meaningless in a place that seems to run on a different time.
*Body Paragraph 2* The college's order therefore depends on a time that the Rock does not share.

Weir also reduces the girls' authority through framing. As they climb, low-angle shots make the pinnacles tower over them, and narrow passages enclose them. The girls are shown gazing upwards, enthralled, yet the same shots make them look small. The college's rules about gloves and snakes are trivial beside a landscape that seems to be swallowing them.
*Body Paragraph 3* Framing, then, turns the college's authority into something the landscape can overwhelm.

The soundtrack completes the picture. Gheorghe Zamfir's pan flute makes the bush seem romantic, but beneath it Weir layers a low rumble that seems to come from the Rock. When Edith flees, her screams merge with a shrieking noise. Beauty and threat are never separated, so the audience cannot fully trust the bush.
*Conclusion* The soundtrack therefore carries the film's argument that order cannot contain nature.

Weir presents Appleyard College as an order that cannot survive contact with the Rock. Its clocks stop, its rules shrink and its voices are drowned out by the sound of the bush. The film does not give nature a simple victory, however. The girls are not conquered so much as taken , and that is what makes the order's failure so unsettling.
*Sample Essay III (High)*

*Introduction*

The opening of *Picnic at Hanging Rock* sets up its argument before the college appears at all. Weir begins with the Rock emerging from mist and Miranda's voice-over: 'What we see and what we seem are but a dream, a dream within a dream.' I agree with the statement, but the film's argument is harder than a story of defeat. The order of Appleyard College is not overpowered by the Rock. It is revealed as a fiction the moment it meets the bush . Weir builds this through the opening, the stopped clocks and the soundtrack.
*Body Paragraph 1*

The opening makes that fiction visible. Before the title card gives its factual details, the Rock is shown first, and Miranda's voice-over frames everything that follows as a dream. Weir inverts the usual hierarchy : nature is presented as the older, more real authority, and the college is an afterthought. When the girls later climb the Rock, they walk into the same dream and accept it without question.
*Body Paragraph 2* The opening therefore settles the film's answer before the disappearance begins.

Time shows most clearly how the college's order gives way to the Rock. The clocks provide the clearest evidence. Appleyard College runs on instructions to return 'at about 8', and Irma is sure they will be back 'long before tea'. At the Rock, Mr Hussey's and Miss McCraw's watches stop at twelve, and Miss McCraw can only suggest that it 'must be something magnetic'. Miranda goes further, rejecting her own watch because its ticking is unbearable, and at the summit she declares that 'everything begins and ends at exactly the right time and place'. Weir shows the college's measured time as a convention the Rock simply does not recognise.
*Body Paragraph 3* The college's clocks are the first thing the Rock makes meaningless.

Sound finishes what time begins. Gheorghe Zamfir's pan flute drifts over the crossing of the stream, making the bush seem freely romantic, but Weir layers a low rumble beneath it and lets Edith's screams merge with a shrieking discord. The audience is never allowed to rest in the beauty. Even after Irma is found, the rush of wind through the rocks keeps the question open. The college wants an explanation, and the film offers only sensation .
*Conclusion* That refusal to explain is what makes the college's failure complete.

Weir's film argues that order is a story people tell themselves, and the Rock refuses to co-operate with it. The opening dream, the stopped watches and the shrieking soundtrack each undermine the college's authority in a different register. Because the film never explains the disappearance, the failure of Appleyard College is not a single moment. It is the condition the whole film describes.